

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	76.0
#2	A+	Salt Lake City	73.4
#3	A+	Oklahoma City	69.7
#4	A	Nashville	67.9
#5	A	Pittsburgh	66.6
#6	A	Hartford	65.6
#7	A-	Austin	61.9

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Sacramento	21.1
#49	D	Detroit	25.1
#48	C-	San Francisco	27.6
#47	C-	San Diego	29.4
#46	C-	Orlando	30.1
#45	C	San Jose	33.3
#44	C	Portland	33.4

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	11 cities
B+ / B / B-	21 cities
C+ / C / C-	16 cities
D	2 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	76.0	3.0%	+4.5%	+1.2%	67.7%	46 days
2	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	73.4	3.4%	+3.1%	+1.8%	72.8%	45 days
3	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	A+	69.7	3.6%	+4.7%	+0.5%	65.7%	55 days
4	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	67.9	3.0%	+1.6%	+1.0%	76.3%	53 days
5	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A	66.6	3.6%	+8.7%	+1.1%	60.3%	65 days
6	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	65.6	2.7%	-0.4%	+1.9%	64.7%	39 days
7	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	61.9	3.2%	+3.2%	+0.7%	74.0%	53 days
8	Richmond Richmond	A-	61.9	3.3%	+5.1%	+0.3%	64.2%	39 days
9	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	A-	60.0	2.5%	+5.1%	+0.1%	66.9%	51 days
10	Columbus Columbus	A-	59.8	3.6%	+0.9%	+1.2%	65.6%	41 days
11	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A-	59.5	3.3%	+8.3%	-0.0%	64.6%	51 days
12	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B+	58.9	3.6%	+6.6%	+0.1%	70.4%	38 days
13	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B+	58.8	3.5%	+4.5%	+0.9%	66.3%	54 days
14	Birmingham Birmingham	B+	58.7	2.2%	-0.1%	+0.6%	60.6%	56 days
15	Memphis Memphis	B+	55.9	4.0%	+6.2%	+0.1%	60.5%	62 days
16	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B+	55.5	3.5%	+7.1%	+0.2%	62.5%	74 days
17	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B+	55.3	4.0%	+2.2%	+1.2%	64.0%	43 days
18	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	B	52.9	3.1%	+3.4%	-0.1%	62.7%	45 days
19	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	52.7	3.6%	+3.1%	+0.3%	69.6%	48 days
20	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	52.6	4.2%	+2.6%	+0.4%	64.5%	50 days
21	Kansas City Kansas City	B	52.4	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.3%	67.9%	45 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
22	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B	51.9	3.6%	-1.5%	+2.7%	65.4%	49 days
23	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	B	50.5	3.7%	+1.8%	+1.1%	62.8%	61 days
24	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	49.9	4.8%	+5.3%	+1.8%	63.6%	45 days
25	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	B-	48.4	4.0%	+3.1%	+0.5%	63.9%	44 days
26	New York New York-Newark-Jersey City	B-	48.0	4.5%	+4.8%	+0.5%	63.3%	51 days
27	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	46.7	3.9%	+1.4%	+0.7%	68.5%	30 days
28	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	46.7	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.0%	65.3%	46 days
29	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	46.6	4.6%	+4.9%	+0.9%	60.0%	66 days
30	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	45.2	5.0%	+7.6%	-0.1%	68.2%	34 days
31	Jacksonville Jacksonville	B-	44.8	4.6%	+5.0%	+0.7%	60.4%	58 days
32	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	B-	44.1	4.0%	+0.0%	+0.6%	69.0%	36 days
33	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	43.9	4.3%	+3.6%	+0.6%	50.8%	48 days
34	Cleveland Cleveland	C+	41.5	3.4%	-1.8%	+0.6%	58.0%	55 days
35	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	39.6	3.8%	+1.4%	-1.6%	67.4%	30 days
36	Fresno Fresno	C+	39.3	8.2%	+7.6%	+0.2%	60.3%	51 days
37	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	C+	39.0	5.2%	+6.7%	-0.8%	65.0%	52 days
38	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	38.8	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.6%	64.8%	35 days
39	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	38.7	3.1%	+3.7%	-0.9%	63.2%	33 days
40	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	38.6	3.6%	+1.2%	-0.1%	64.2%	37 days
41	Cincinnati Cincinnati	C	36.5	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.5%	63.1%	45 days
42	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	35.8	3.6%	+10.2%	-1.3%	59.0%	36 days
43	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	35.0	5.1%	+7.5%	+0.2%	60.4%	54 days

#	METRO	GRADE		SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
44	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C		33.4	4.9%	+4.8%	-0.7%	66.2%	49 days
45	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C		33.3	4.0%	+0.6%	-0.2%	64.3%	24 days
46	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C-		30.1	4.4%	+0.4%	+0.2%	64.0%	67 days
47	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C-		29.4	4.4%	+2.4%	+0.3%	62.0%	38 days
48	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C-		27.6	4.1%	+0.5%	-0.5%	64.5%	29 days
49	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D		25.1	4.7%	-1.1%	+0.0%	61.3%	45 days
50	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	D		21.1	4.8%	+2.5%	-0.3%	60.1%	39 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

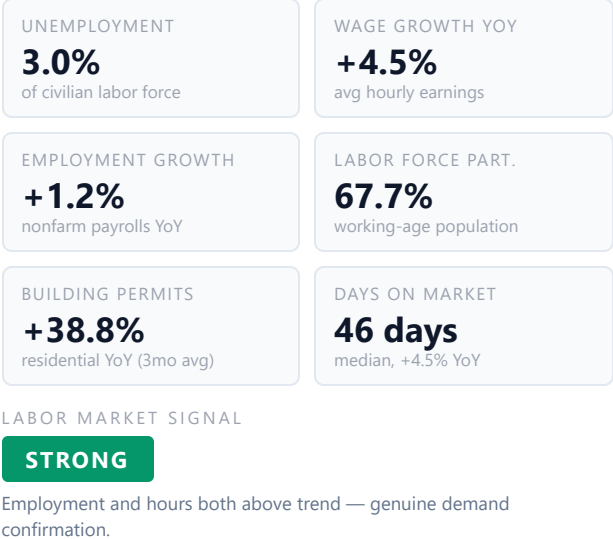
76.0th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh's A+ overall grade is driven by its exceptionally tight labor market, with a 3.0% unemployment rate and a 67.67% labor force participation rate, creating a highly competitive hiring environment. This challenges businesses in attracting and retaining top talent.

Raleigh's housing market presents a nuanced picture, with a below-average cost of living and an aggressively expanding housing supply, up 38.82% year-over-year. However, the days on market have increased by 4.5% to 46 days, which, given the city's strong employment growth and reasonable cost of living, can be seen as a stabilizing force rather than a warning sign.

Raleigh offers businesses a unique combination of a highly skilled workforce, a competitive labor market, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the primary risk for businesses relocating to Raleigh is the potential erosion of its affordability advantage, as demand for housing continues to outpace supply.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

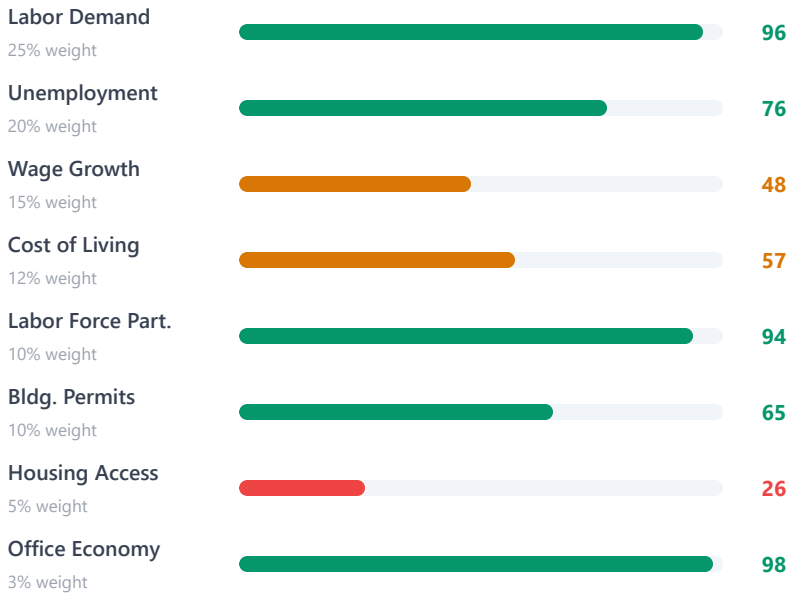
A+

EXCELLENT

73.4th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

72.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+14.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City earns an A+ grade, with a single most important takeaway being its exceptional economic character, driven by a low unemployment rate of 3.40% and top-tier labor force participation of 72.77%. The city's nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% YoY signals a rapidly expanding market, outpacing many of its peers. This momentum story is compelling, making Salt Lake City economically vibrant and attractive to businesses and talent alike.

The city's housing market is characterized by homes selling quickly, with an average of just 45 days on market. While the city's above-average building permit growth of +14.73% YoY suggests that housing supply is keeping pace with demand, the rapid sales pace may still create barriers to talent attraction. The city's deep professional talent pool, as evidenced by its 98th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share, makes it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses.

In summary, Salt Lake City offers businesses a unique combination of a healthy labor market, rapid job growth, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an excellent location for companies seeking to expand or establish a presence. However, the city's competitive housing market poses a significant risk, potentially impacting talent attraction and retention efforts.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

A+

EXCELLENT

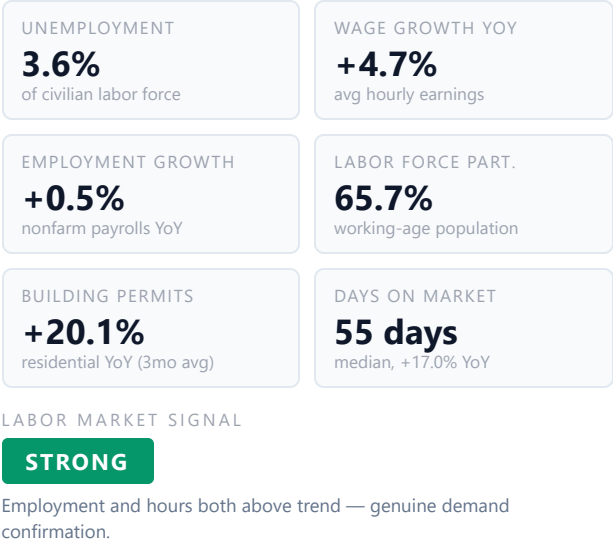
69.7th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic performance, with a strong labor market and increasing consumer spending power. The city's nonfarm employment growth of +0.52% YoY and solid wage growth of +4.70% YoY indicate a healthy expansion.

The city's cost of living composite score of 1.27 makes it one of the most affordable metros, offering a significant cost advantage for businesses and residents. Meanwhile, the housing market is stabilizing, with building permits growing at an above-average rate of +20.14% YoY, and days on market increasing by 17.0% YoY, now averaging 55 days. This suggests a slowing market, which could ease affordability pressure and give buyers negotiating room.

Oklahoma City presents a unique combination of a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and a stabilizing housing market, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the primary risk lies in the potential for the housing market to continue slowing, which could impact demand and affordability if not managed carefully.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

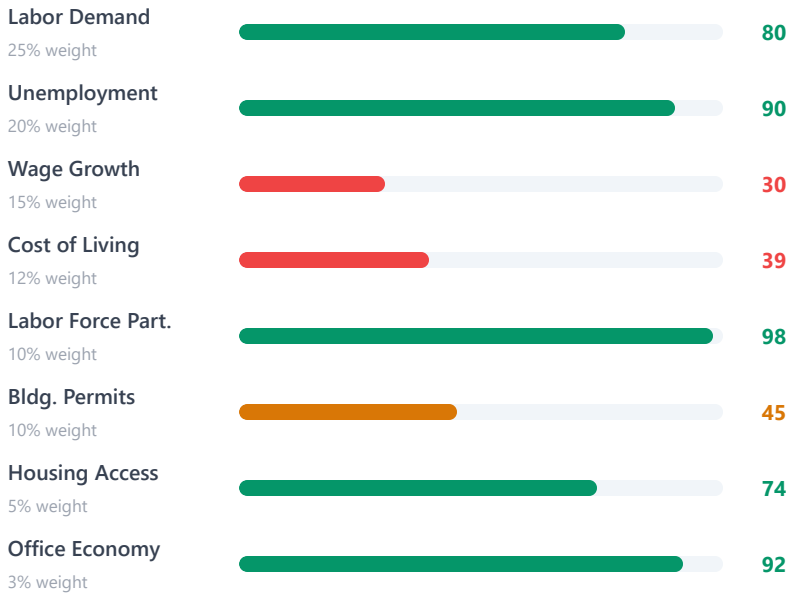
A

VERY GOOD

67.9th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

76.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-8.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days

median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville's economy earns an A grade, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market and rapid job creation, with a 3.00% unemployment rate and 1.03% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. This strong momentum gives businesses significant hiring competition and workers leverage.

The 76.27% labor force participation rate indicates a deep labor pool, making Nashville an attractive location for companies seeking to hire. However, the 1.62% wage growth suggests weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The above-average cost of living, with a composite score of 3.16, means businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Nashville offers a unique combination of a tight labor market, rapid job creation, and a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 92nd percentile for office and professional worker share. However, the primary risk is the potential for wage pressures to rise as the labor market continues to tighten, which could erode the city's cost advantage.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

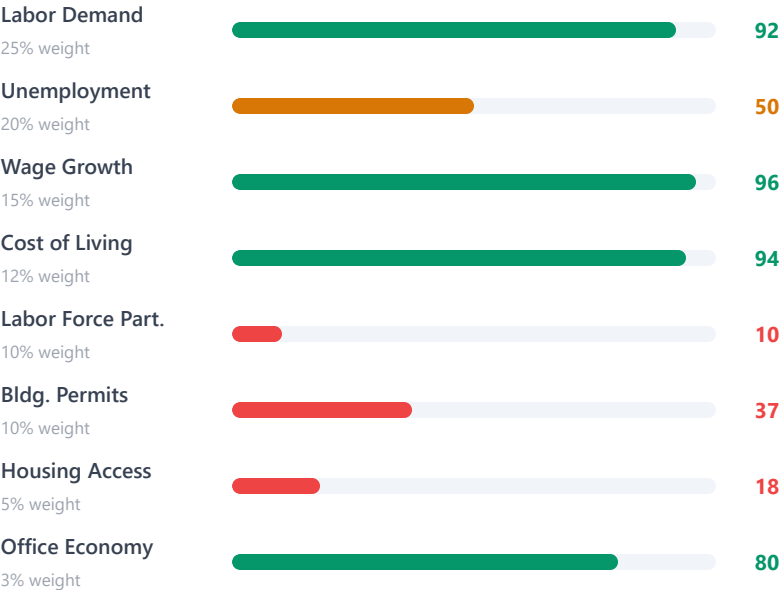
A

VERY GOOD

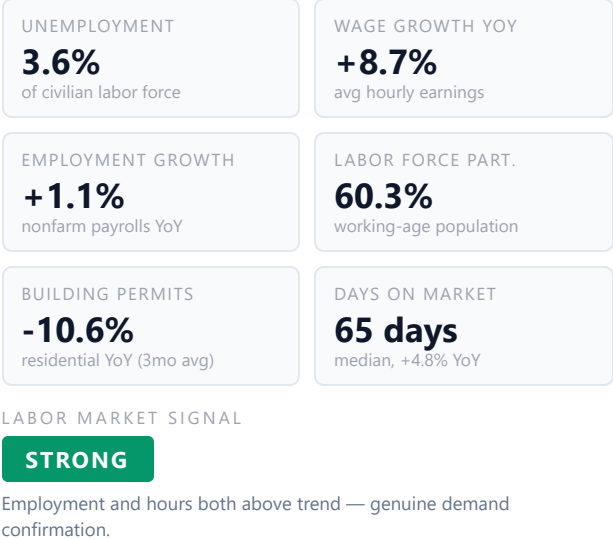
66.6th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh's economy is characterized by rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at +1.07% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier, making it an attractive location for businesses, particularly those in the knowledge economy. The city boasts an extremely affordable cost of living, with a composite index score of 1.11, ranking it among the most affordable metros in the dataset. Pittsburgh also has a deep professional talent pool, with an 80th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share.

However, labor force participation is critically low, at 60.33%, indicating a significant structural constraint on workforce availability. Wage growth is rising rapidly at +8.65% year-over-year, posing a real cost pressure for employers. The housing market also presents a challenge, with days on market increasing by +4.8% year-over-year, albeit still at a moderate 65 days.

Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique blend of rapid job growth, affordable cost of living, and access to a deep professional talent pool. However, the primary risk lies in the city's critically low labor force participation and rapidly rising wages, which may pose significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate, particularly in terms of workforce availability and labor costs.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

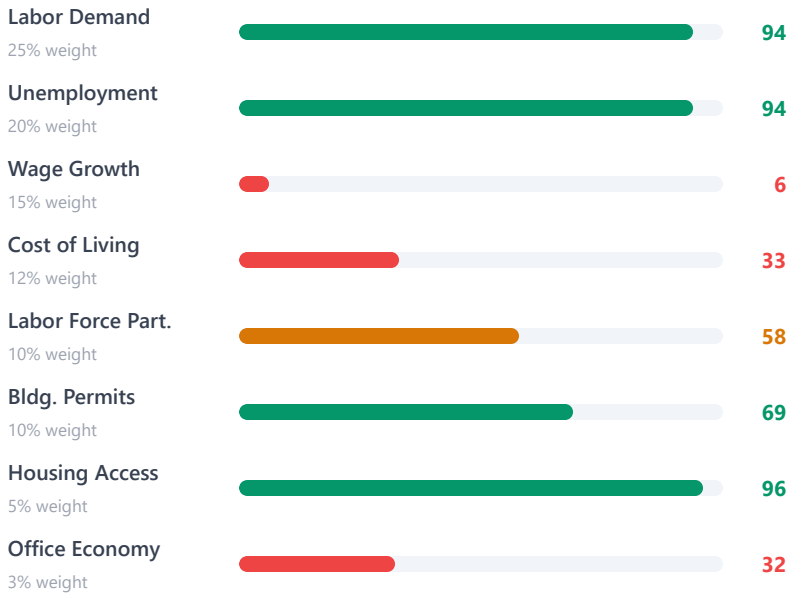
A

VERY GOOD

65.6th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-0.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+16.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, +30.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford's economy boasts a remarkably tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 2.70% and rapid job creation, as evidenced by 1.88% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, earning it an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.6th percentile.

The city's highly competitive job market, where workers have leverage and businesses face hiring challenges, drives this momentum story. However, wage growth has been stagnant, with a -0.36% year-over-year change, and the cost of living is above average, with a composite score of 3.37, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract talent.

Hartford offers a business a highly competitive and expanding economy, with a talented workforce and a stabilizing housing market, with homes taking 30% more days to sell than last year, resulting in an average of 39 days on market. However, the primary risk is the potential for wage pressure, given the tight labor market and above-average cost of living, which could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

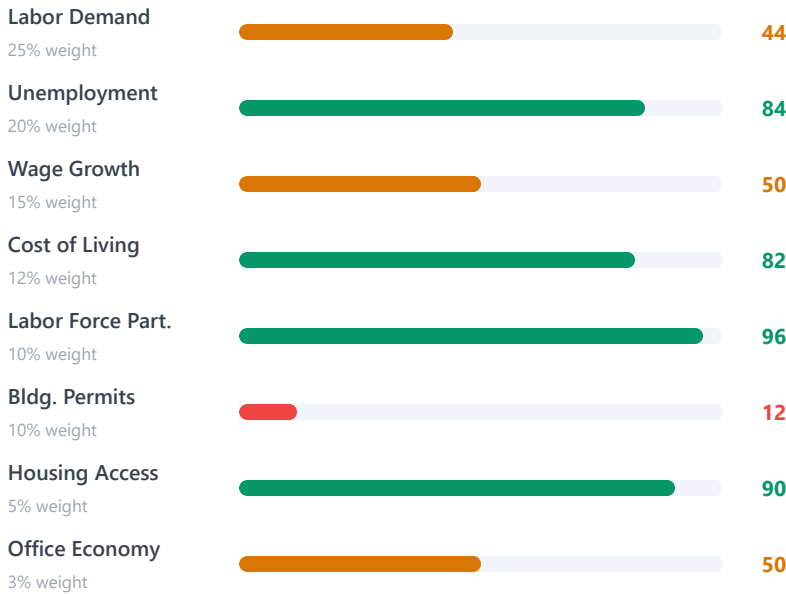
A-

GOOD

61.9th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

74.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-29.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days

median, +20.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin's economy earns an A- grade with a 61.9th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.20%. This tight labor market gives workers considerable leverage, but is mitigated by a deep labor pool, as evidenced by a labor force participation rate of 73.99%. Additionally, Austin's cost of living composite score of 1.44 makes it among the most affordable metros, offering a substantial advantage in terms of lower real-wage requirements and higher consumer purchasing power.

However, the data also reveals notable tensions. The sharp decline in building permits, down 29.44% year-over-year, signals a contraction in housing supply, which could lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. The days on market have increased by 20.4% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 53 days to sell, indicating a slowing market.

Austin's unique combination of a tight labor market, deep labor pool, and affordable cost of living makes it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the primary risk lies in the potential demand erosion signaled by the decline in building permits and slowing housing market, which could impact the city's long-term economic momentum and affordability.

Richmond

Richmond

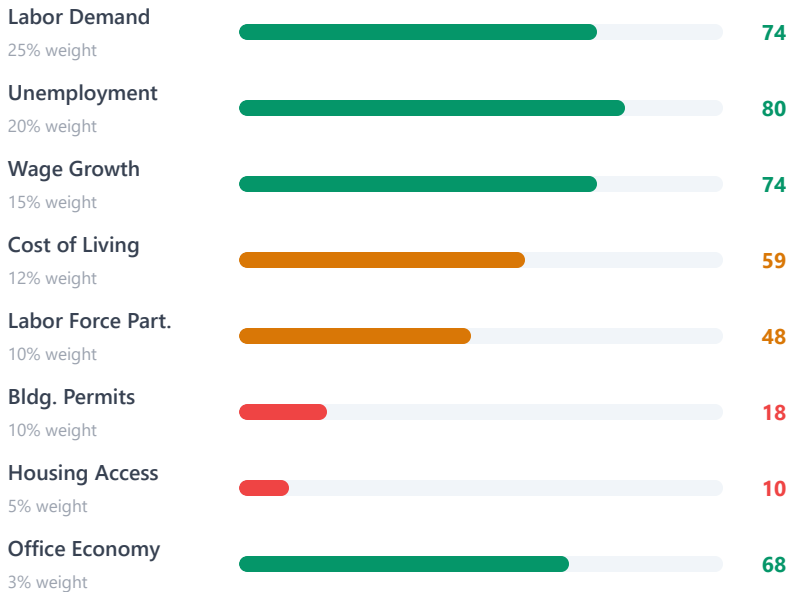
A-

GOOD

61.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.2%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-20.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, -11.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond's A- grade is driven by its exceptional labor market, with a 3.30% unemployment rate and 0.29% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, making it an attractive location for businesses. The city's strong labor market, combined with 5.12% year-over-year wage growth, suggests a healthy expansion with workers having leverage.

However, the data reveals tensions beneath the surface. Building permits have declined 20.27% year-over-year, indicating a housing supply squeeze that could lead to affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. The extremely fast-moving housing market, with homes selling in just 39 days on average, and a 11.4% year-over-year decrease in days on market, further exacerbate the issue.

Richmond's strong and expanding labor market, with a highly skilled workforce ranking in the 68th percentile, is a significant draw for businesses. However, the emerging housing supply squeeze poses a primary risk, potentially impacting affordability and workforce attraction. With its exceptionally low unemployment rate and solid wage growth, Richmond is an attractive location, but decision-makers must carefully consider the potential long-term consequences of a tightening housing market.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

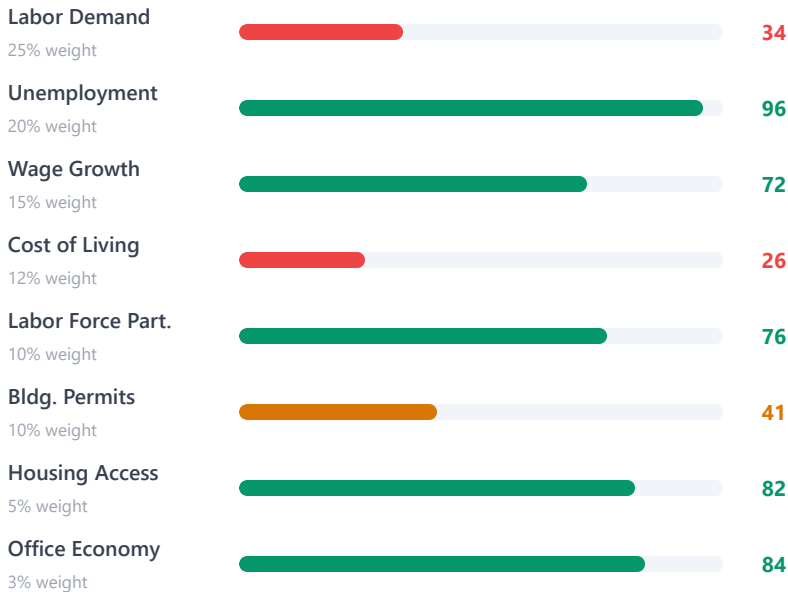
A-

GOOD

60.0th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

66.9%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-10.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

51 days

median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis earns an A- grade, driven by its exceptional labor market and attractive workforce profile, with a 2.50% unemployment rate and 84th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share.

The city's strong labor market is paired with solid wage growth of 5.10% year-over-year, suggesting a positive outlook for consumer spending. However, nuances in the data reveal tensions that deserve attention, including nonfarm employment growth of +0.11% year-over-year, which flags a potential risk of economic deceleration. The cost of living composite score of 3.68 indicates an above-average cost of living, which may erode the real purchasing power of workers despite their nominal wage gains.

Indianapolis offers businesses a talented and productive workforce, but with a tight labor market that demands competitive hiring practices. The primary risk lies in the city's below-average employment growth and slowing housing market, which may signal underlying demand weakness and warrant careful consideration from decision-makers.

Columbus

Columbus

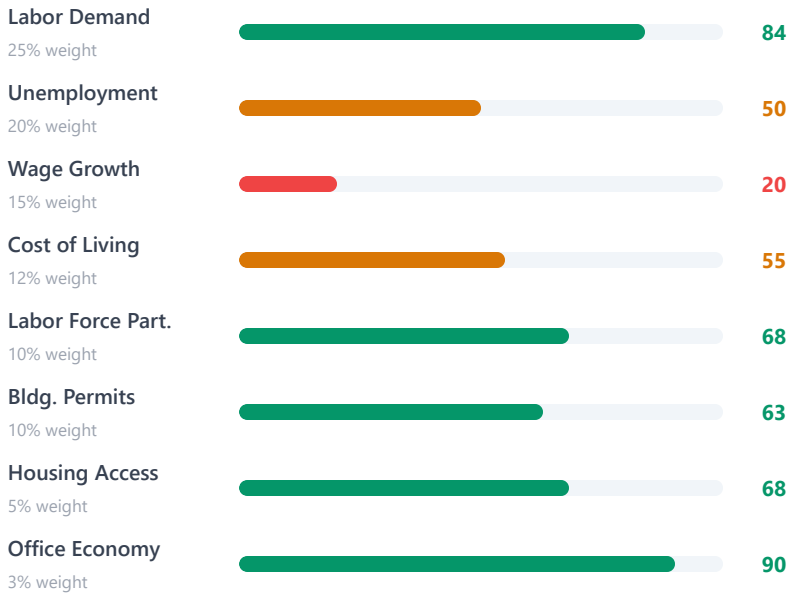
A-

GOOD

59.8th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+8.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

41 days

median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns an A- grade, driven by its strong economic momentum, with nonfarm employment growth of +1.17% YoY, ranking in the 84th percentile, and a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 90th percentile for office and professional worker share. This combination positions the city as an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters.

However, wage growth, at +0.86% YoY, lags, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The housing market is also slowing, with days on market increasing by 10.8% YoY to an average of 41 days, a relatively fast market. This slowdown can be seen as a stabilizing force, given the strong employment growth and above-average building permits, suggesting that supply is finally catching up to demand.

Columbus offers businesses a dynamic and expanding market with access to a deep professional talent pool, making it an ideal location for knowledge-economy companies. However, the primary risk lies in the sluggish wage growth, which may signal underlying weaknesses in the labor market and potentially impact the city's long-term economic sustainability.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

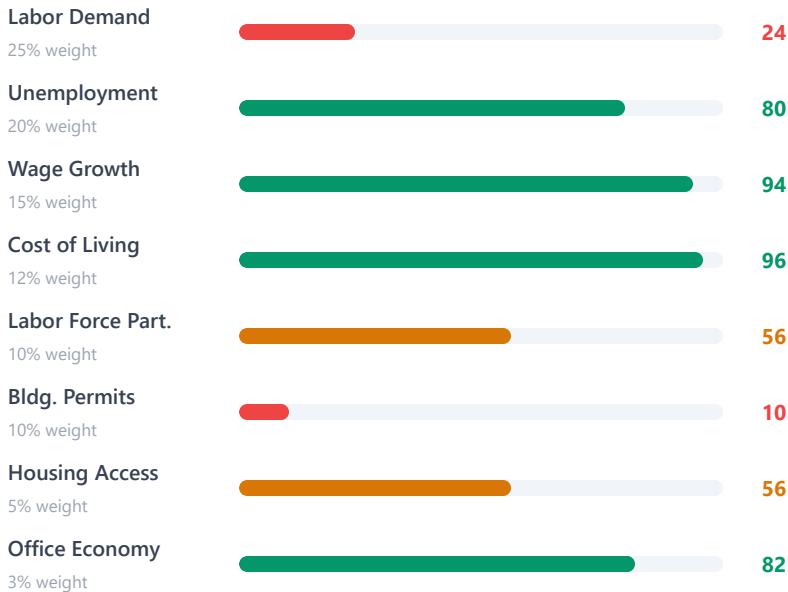
A-

GOOD

59.5th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+8.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-30.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

51 days

median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta's economy earns an A- grade, driven by its exceptional labor market and affordable cost of living. The city's 3.30% unemployment rate and 8.27% year-over-year wage growth demonstrate a highly competitive job market where workers have significant leverage.

Atlanta's cost of living composite index of 1.03 indicates it is one of the most affordable metros, offering a strong cost advantage for businesses and residents. However, the city's nonfarm employment growth has stalled, with a year-over-year change of -0.01%, suggesting economic deceleration. The sharp decline in building permits of -30.90% year-over-year indicates a contracting housing supply, which could lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties.

Atlanta offers businesses a highly skilled and affordable workforce, with a deep professional talent pool and low cost of living. However, the primary risk for businesses considering location in Atlanta is the potential for economic deceleration and affordability stress, driven by stagnant employment growth and a contracting housing supply.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

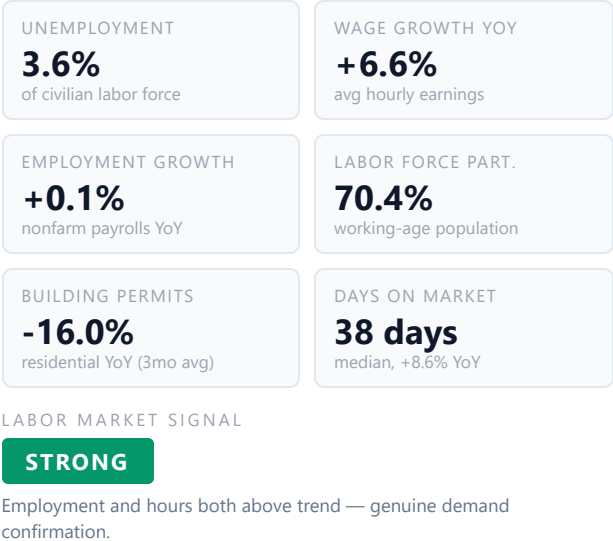
58.9th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver's economy earns a B+ grade, with its above-average performance across key metrics, driven by a deep labor pool, where 70.39% of working-age adults are employed or actively looking for work, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire. Wage growth is robust, with hourly earnings rising 6.57% year-over-year, indicating a competitive job market. However, this rapid wage growth also poses a cost pressure for employers, which must be carefully considered.

Despite these strengths, the data reveals tensions. Building permits have declined by 15.96% year-over-year, suggesting a potential tightening of the housing supply. The days on market have increased by 8.6% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 38 days to sell. This slowdown in the housing market, combined with the decline in building permits, may indicate softening demand, which could have broader economic implications.

Overall, Denver offers businesses a talented and engaged workforce, with a strong labor market and rising wages. However, the primary risk is the potential for softening demand, driven by a slowing housing market and declining building permits, which could impact the city's long-term economic growth and affordability.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

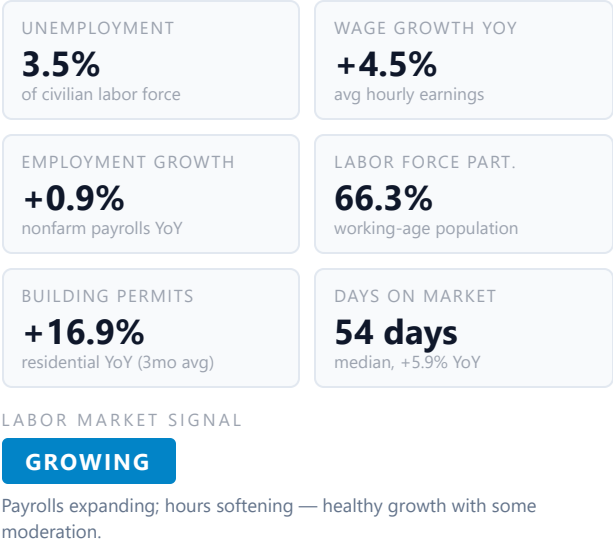
58.8th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area earns a B+ grade, ranking 58.8th among 50 US metros, driven by a healthy labor market with a 3.50% unemployment rate and 66.34% labor force participation. This indicates a constructive and engaged workforce, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The area also boasts a deep professional talent pool, ranking 88th percentile for office and professional worker share.

However, beneath this positive surface, there are nuances and tensions worth exploring. The nonfarm employment growth rate of +0.87% YoY is below average, ranking 38th percentile, suggesting economic deceleration and a risk signal worth watching. The days on market are increasing by 5.9% YoY, indicating a slowing market, which may be a sign of demand erosion, particularly given the weak employment growth.

Phoenix offers a business a talented and engaged workforce, a competitive housing market, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the primary risk is the potential for economic deceleration, driven by below-average employment growth, which may impact the demand for housing and ultimately, the overall attractiveness of the location for businesses.

Birmingham

Birmingham

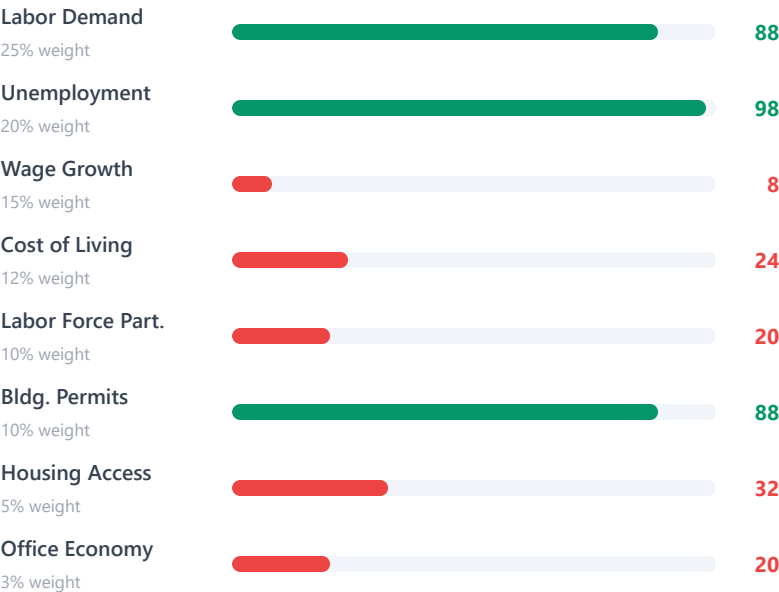
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

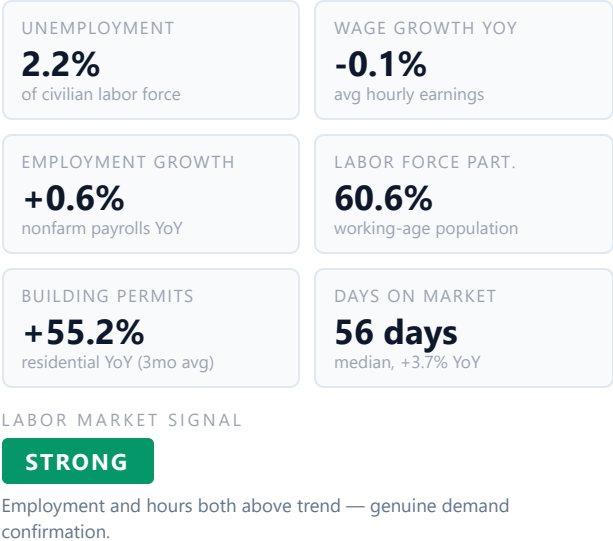
58.7th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham's economy stands out with an overall grade of B+, driven by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.20% and rapid nonfarm employment growth of 0.61% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with strong job creation momentum. The city's labor force participation rate of 60.56% suggests a shallow labor pool, limiting the available workforce.

Despite strong employment growth, wage growth has been stagnant, with a -0.12% YoY change, indicating limited leverage for workers. The city's cost of living composite score of 3.72, ranking in the 24th percentile, suggests an above-average cost of living, requiring businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The housing market is showing signs of stabilization, with days on market increasing by 3.7% YoY to an average of 56 days, indicating a moderate market pace.

Birmingham offers businesses a strong job market with rapid employment growth, but with the caveat that the labor pool is shallow and wages are stagnant. The primary risk for businesses is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and limited labor force participation, which may require strategic compensation and benefits packages to remain competitive.

Memphis

Memphis

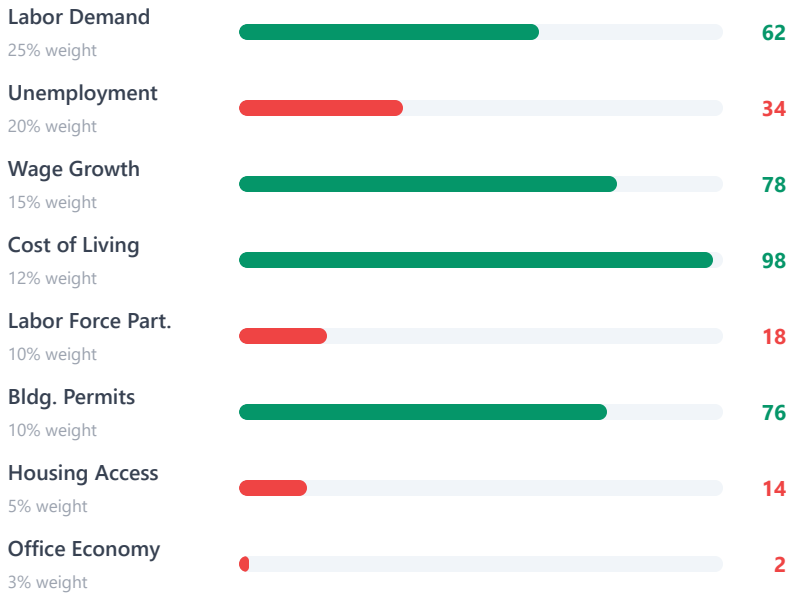
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.9th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

62 days

median, +6.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns a B+ grade, driven by its strong economic performance, with a low unemployment rate of 4.00% and modest nonfarm employment growth of +0.06% YoY. The city's cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 0.48, makes it one of the most affordable metros, supporting a positive environment for consumer spending and business operations. Solid wage growth of +6.16% YoY further underscores this favorable climate.

However, beneath the surface, tensions emerge. The housing market is slowing, with homes taking an average of 62 days to sell and a year-over-year increase of +6.9% in days on market. This stabilizing force is evident in the strong employment growth and rising building permits. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 2nd percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of affordability, solid wage growth, and a healthy labor market expansion. However, the primary risk lies in the city's limited professional workforce and low labor force participation rate of 60.48%, which may hinder talent attraction and availability. Businesses must carefully evaluate their workforce needs before making a location decision.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

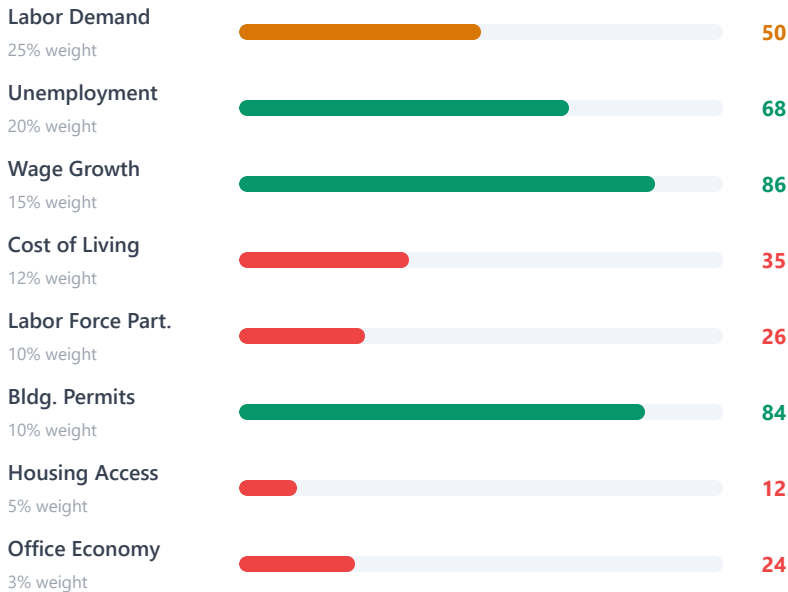
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.5th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+41.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

74 days

median, +10.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami's economy earns a B+ grade, driven by its above-average performance, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and robust wage growth of 7.12% year-over-year. The strong wage growth is a significant advantage, but it may be offset by the city's above-average cost of living, with a composite score of 3.31. The labor force participation rate of 62.53% indicates a relatively shallow labor pool, tempering the city's overall performance.

The housing market presents a complex picture, with building permits increasing by 41.11% year-over-year, indicating an aggressive expansion of housing supply. However, the days on market have increased by 10.4% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 74 days to sell, suggesting a slowing market. This tension is noteworthy, as the strong employment and wage growth would normally be expected to drive housing demand.

In summary, Miami offers businesses a dynamic labor market with strong wage growth, but also presents challenges such as a shallow labor pool and high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses is the potential for labor costs to escalate, making it essential to carefully consider compensation packages to attract and retain top talent.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

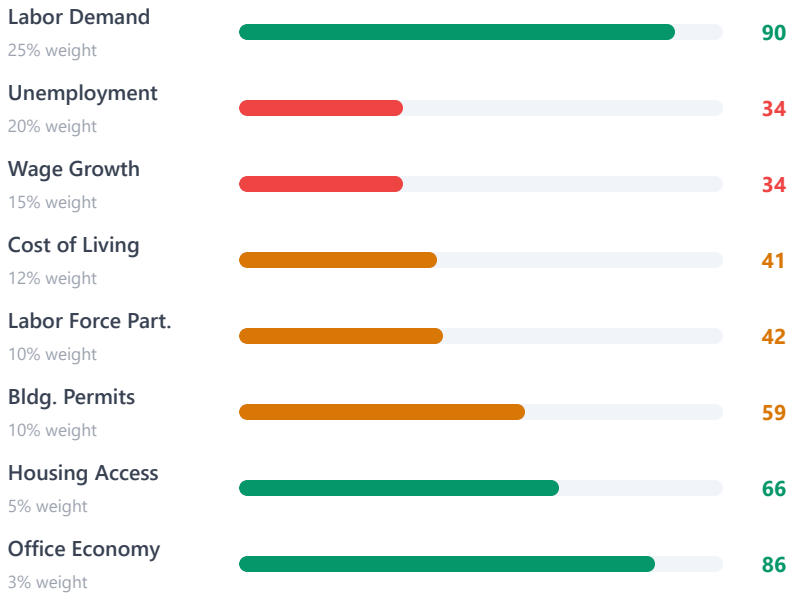
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.3th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+4.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

43 days

median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia's economy earns a B+ grade, driven by its strong nonfarm employment growth of +1.16% YoY, ranking it in the top tier and indicating an expanding market. The city's deep professional talent pool, ranking 86th percentile for office and professional worker share, further supports this growth.

However, this growth is accompanied by sluggish wage growth of +2.21% YoY, which may indicate a lower cost environment for employers but also raises concerns about worker bargaining power. The unemployment rate of 4.00% is slightly elevated, suggesting some labor market slack. The days on market for homes has increased by 10.3% YoY, with an average of 43 days, indicating a slowing housing market.

Philadelphia's economy offers a dynamic and expanding market with a talented workforce, but the primary risk lies in the potential for labor market imbalances and a slowing housing market. As the city continues to grow, businesses must be mindful of these tensions and their potential impact on the local economy and workforce.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

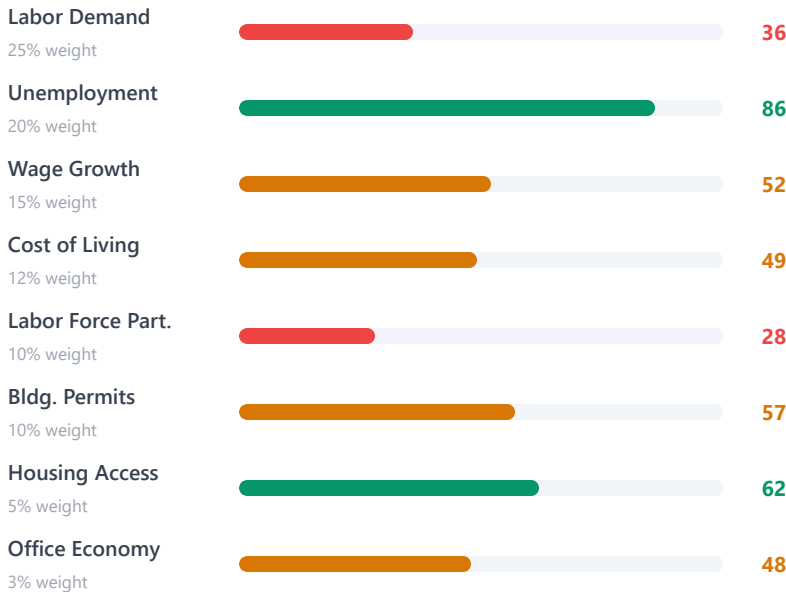
B

AVERAGE

52.9th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+3.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Louisville's economy earns a B grade, driven by a tight labor market with an unemployment rate of 3.10%, but tempered by a shallow labor pool with a labor force participation rate of 62.74%. This complex picture presents a challenging environment for businesses, with significant hiring competition and limited labor options.

The city's sluggish nonfarm employment growth, at -0.06%, and increasing days on market, up 9.8% year-over-year, suggest a softening of demand. This is further supported by the average of 45 days to sell, indicating a slowing market. The combination of these factors warrants caution, as it may signal a broader economic slowdown.

In Louisville, businesses face a highly competitive labor market, but also significant hiring challenges due to a shallow labor pool. The primary risk is the potential for economic deceleration, driven by weak employment growth and softening demand, which could impact the city's long-term economic viability.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B

AVERAGE

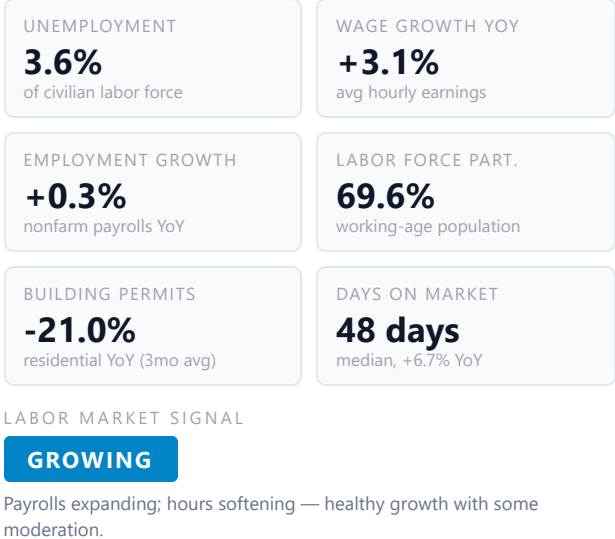
52.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington's strong labor market, with a 69.61% labor force participation rate, offers a significant hiring advantage and strong consumer purchasing power, backed by an overall cost of living composite of 1.43, making it one of the most affordable metros. This combination of a deep labor pool and affordable cost of living makes it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention.

However, the city's housing supply and demand dynamics are concerning. The 20.96% year-over-year decline in building permits signals a contracting housing supply, which may lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. The increasing days on market, with homes taking 6.7% more days to sell than last year, averaging 48 days, suggests a slowing market and demand erosion, rather than a healthy normalization.

The city's average nonfarm employment growth of 0.33% year-over-year does not indicate strong enough job creation to drive demand, reinforcing the narrative of demand erosion. The primary risk lies in the potential for demand erosion and affordability stress due to the declining housing supply, which may impact the city's long-term economic momentum and attractiveness to businesses and workers alike.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

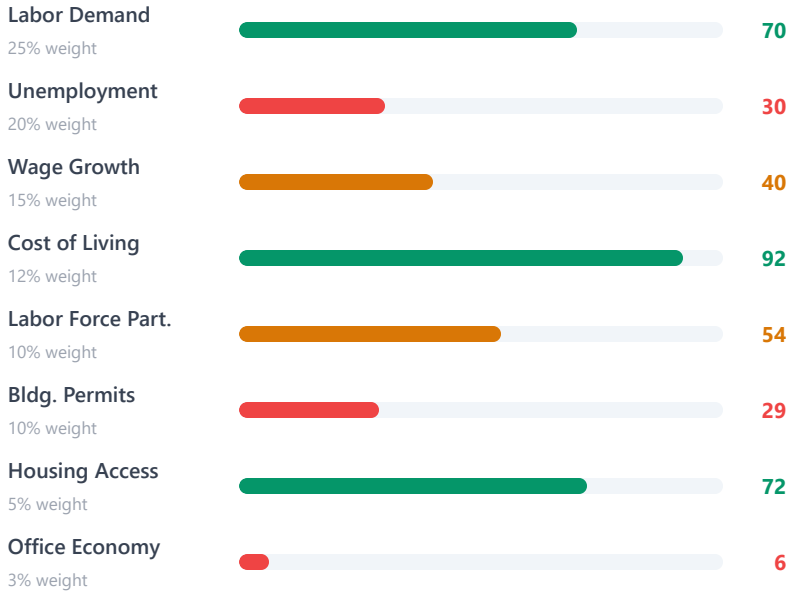
B

AVERAGE

52.6th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

50 days

median, +11.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston's economy earns a B grade, ranking 52.6th out of 50 US metros, driven by above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.43% YoY. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.19 indicates it is among the most affordable metros, but this advantage is tempered by a low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 6th percentile, constraining knowledge-economy businesses.

A key tension in the data is the combination of strong employment growth with sharply declining building permits, down 12.89% YoY, suggesting a housing supply squeeze is building, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and make it harder to attract workers. The days on market metric, up 11.1% YoY to 50 days, indicates a slowing housing market, potentially signaling softening demand.

Houston offers businesses a unique combination of strong employment growth and affordability, making it an attractive location for expansion. However, the primary risk is the potential for a housing supply squeeze to drive up costs and make it harder to attract top talent, particularly in knowledge-economy sectors.

Kansas City

Kansas City

B

AVERAGE

52.4th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

67.9%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+5.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, -11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City's economy earns a grade of B, or 52.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and high labor force participation of 67.91%, indicating a healthy and engaged workforce. However, this is offset by a stagnant job market, with -0.31% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, and rapidly rising wages at 6.80% year-over-year, which could benefit workers but increase labor costs for employers.

The city's affordability is a notable strength, with a cost of living composite score of 1.41, ranking it among the most affordable metros. However, this advantage is eroding due to a fast-moving housing market, with homes selling in just 45 days on average, and a -11.8% year-over-year change in days on market, indicating a market that is heating up. This tension between affordability and housing demand is a key consideration for businesses looking to relocate or expand in Kansas City.

Kansas City offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a highly engaged workforce, but the city's stagnant job market and rapidly rising wages pose significant risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering Kansas City is the potential for labor costs to outpace productivity gains, making it essential to carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in this market.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

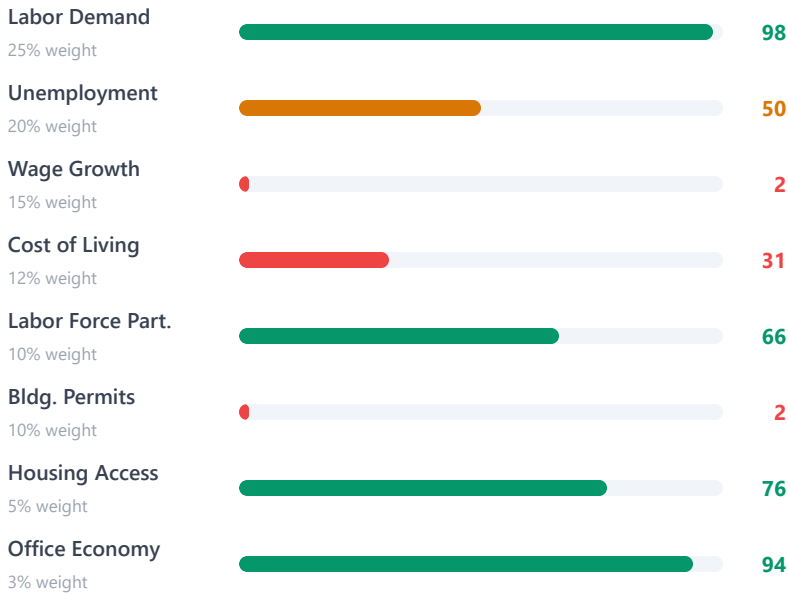
B

AVERAGE

51.9th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-1.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+2.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.4%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-39.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

49 days

median, +13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte's economy is characterized by rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth reaching 2.69% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier. This momentum is supported by a deep professional talent pool, as evidenced by its 94th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share.

However, this growth is not without its challenges, as wage growth has been stagnant, with hourly earnings declining by 1.52% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance. The city's housing market is also experiencing a slowdown, with building permits declining sharply by 39.50% year-over-year, and days on market increasing by 13.9% year-over-year, with homes now taking an average of 49 days to sell.

Overall, Charlotte offers businesses a talented workforce and a growing economy, but the primary risk is a potential housing supply squeeze and its impact on affordability and workforce attraction. As the city's economy continues to expand, businesses will need to carefully consider the implications of a tightening labor market and rising costs of living on their operations and talent recruitment strategies.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

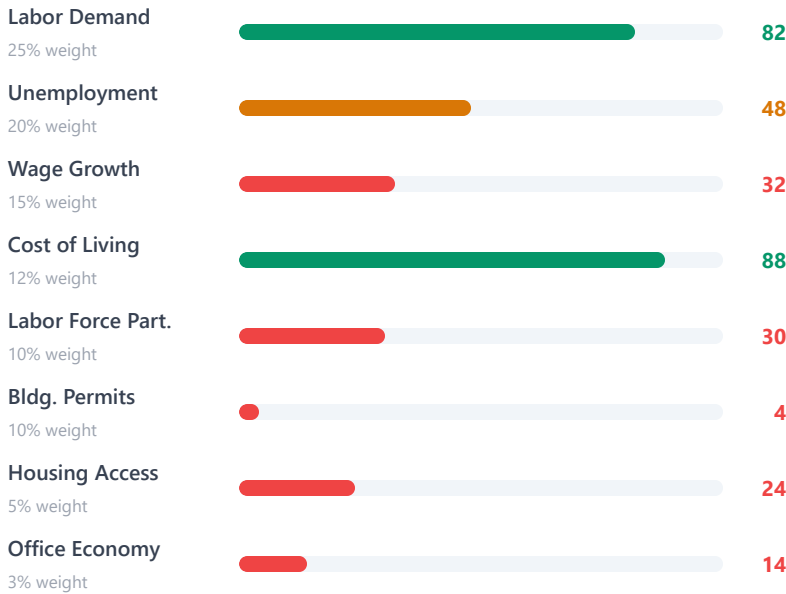
B

AVERAGE

50.5th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-37.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

61 days

median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio's economy earns a grade of B, driven by its top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +1.09% YoY, indicating a rapidly expanding job market. The city's extremely affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 1.33, ranking it among the most affordable metros in the dataset, complements this growth.

However, this growth is not without its challenges. The labor force participation rate of 62.78% suggests a shallow labor pool, and the sharp decline in building permits, down 37.55% YoY, signals a looming housing supply squeeze that could erode the city's affordability advantage.

San Antonio's constrained housing supply and shallow labor pool pose significant risks, including affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. The city's days on market metric, increasing by 1.7% YoY, suggests a slowing market that may be indicative of demand erosion. Despite its attractive cost of living and rapidly expanding job market, San Antonio's primary risk lies in its constrained housing supply and shallow labor pool, which could undermine the city's economic momentum.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

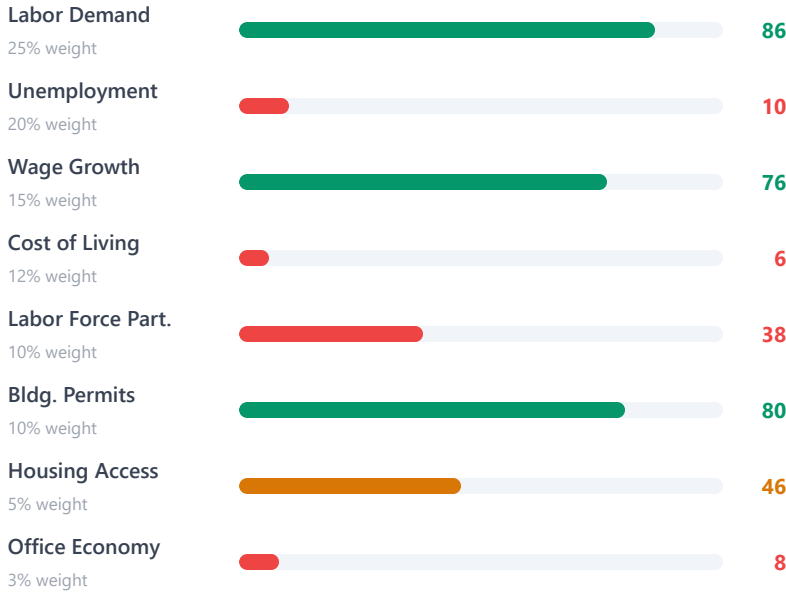
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.9th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

63.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+20.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim earns a below-average overall grade, with a 4.80% unemployment rate, a significant concern indicating severe labor market weakness and flagging consumer spending risk. The city's strong nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% year-over-year and solid wage growth of +5.33% year-over-year suggest an economically expanding market with rapid job creation and positive consumer spending.

However, the city's cost of living composite score of 5.59 is a major constraint, ranking it among the most expensive metros. This high cost of living, combined with a low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 8th percentile, poses significant challenges for talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The tension between strong wage growth and high cost of living is particularly noteworthy, as workers may be gaining in nominal terms but seeing limited real purchasing power gains.

The city's housing market is showing signs of stabilization, with building permits growing at +20.24% year-over-year, which could help alleviate some of the affordability pressures. Overall, Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers a rapidly expanding job market, but its highly expensive cost of living and shallow labor pool pose significant challenges for businesses, including constrained consumer spending power and talent acquisition challenges.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

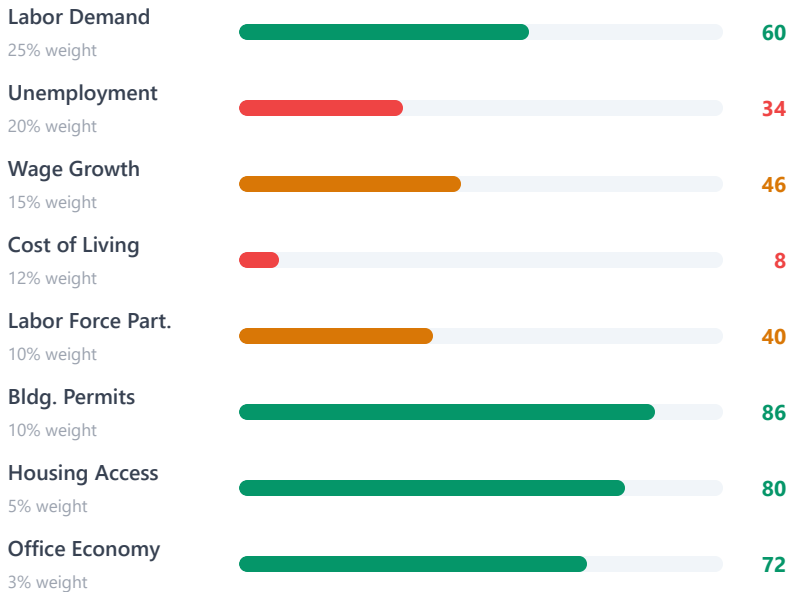
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.4th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

63.9%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+55.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood earns a B- grade, with a below-average economic performance marked by a 4.00% unemployment rate, indicating labor market slack that may weaken local consumer demand. However, the +0.51% nonfarm employment growth YoY suggests a healthy expansion, creating jobs. This tension between labor market slack and job growth defines the city's economic character, making it a complex market for businesses to navigate.

The high cost of living in Grand Rapids, with a composite score of 5.56, is a significant concern, constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. However, the city's housing supply is expanding aggressively, with building permits increasing by +55.17% YoY, and homes taking longer to sell, with days on market rising by +15.8% YoY to an average of 44 days. This slowing market could be a stabilizing force, giving buyers more negotiating room and easing affordability pressure.

Grand Rapids offers businesses a unique combination of labor market slack and healthy job growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire. However, the high cost of living and slowing housing market pose significant risks, potentially constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

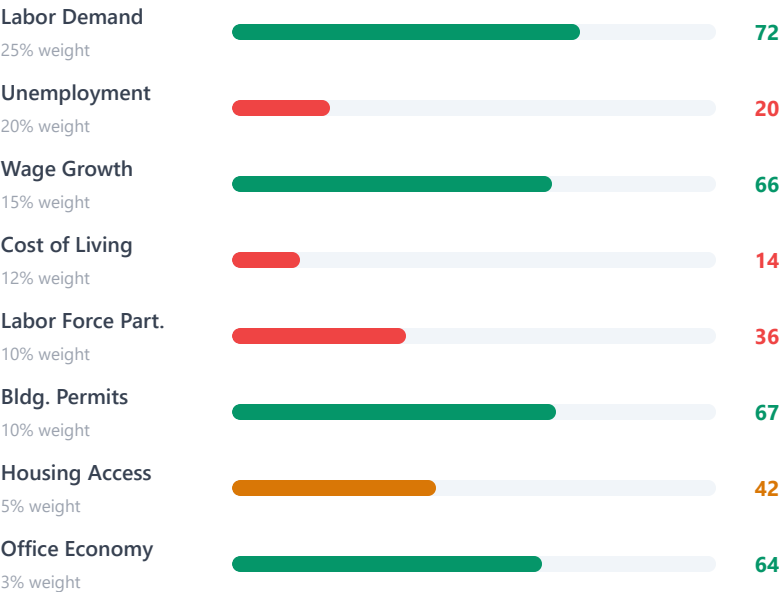
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

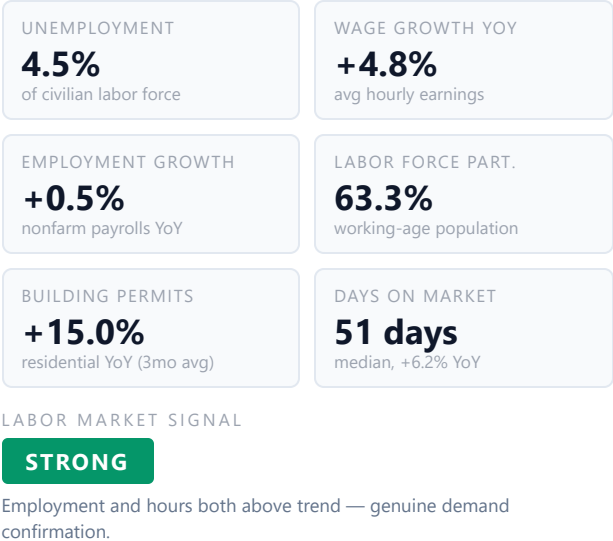
48.0th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York's economy earns a below-average overall grade of 48.0th percentile, with a 4.50% unemployment rate indicating labor market slack, making it easier for businesses to hire. However, the city's +0.48% YoY nonfarm employment growth and +4.84% YoY wage growth suggest a healthy expansion and positive consumer spending outlook.

Despite these positives, New York's cost of living composite score of 5.01 places it in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros. This high cost of living is a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The labor force participation rate of 63.30% is below average, suggesting a shallow labor pool.

New York offers businesses a unique combination of a growing economy and a highly skilled workforce, but at a high cost. The primary risk for businesses is the city's extremely high cost of living, which may limit their ability to attract and retain top talent, and ultimately impact their bottom line.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

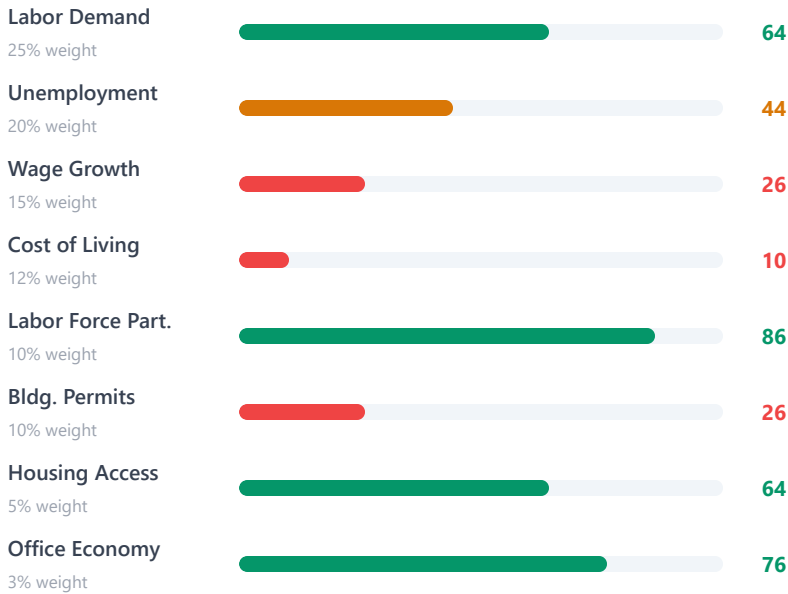
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.7th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

68.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-15.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

30 days

median, +20.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston's economy earns a B- grade, ranking 46.7th out of 50 US metros, with a labor force participation rate of 68.47%, a top-tier strength indicating a deep and engaged labor pool. However, this is offset by a cost of living composite score of 5.25, making it one of the most expensive metros.

Boston's nonfarm employment growth of +0.73% YoY is above average, suggesting a healthy expansion, but wage growth of +1.42% YoY is below the national average, potentially signaling weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 20.0% YoY to an average of 30 days, and building permits declining by -14.97% YoY, raising concerns about a potential tightening of housing supply and exacerbating affordability issues.

Boston offers businesses a highly engaged and participatory labor force, but at a high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Boston is the potential for demand erosion, driven by slowing housing market growth and declining building permits, which could further constrain an already expensive and competitive environment.

St. Louis

St. Louis

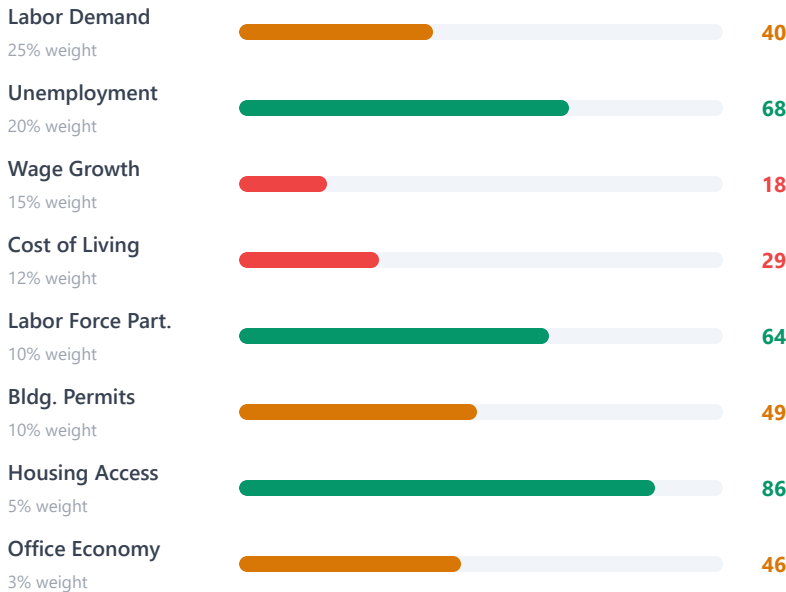
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.7th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-7.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

46 days

median, +17.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns a B- grade, ranking 46.7th among 50 US metros, with a single most important takeaway being its stagnant wage growth of +0.66% YoY, a bottom-tier ranking that raises concerns about consumer spending power and market health. The city's 3.50% unemployment rate and 65.27% labor force participation rate suggest a constructive labor market, but wage stagnation is a significant concern.

The housing market presents a notable tension, with homes taking 46 days to sell and a 17.9% year-over-year increase, indicating a slowing market. This slowdown, combined with a below-average cost of living composite score of 3.50, suggests that the city's affordability advantage may be a double-edged sword. The low cost of living is attractive, but the slowing housing market may indicate weakening demand or a normalization of the market after rapid growth.

St. Louis offers a relatively stable labor market and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to minimize costs. However, the primary risk is the potential for weakening consumer demand, driven by stagnant wage growth and a slowing housing market, which could impact the city's long-term economic vitality.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

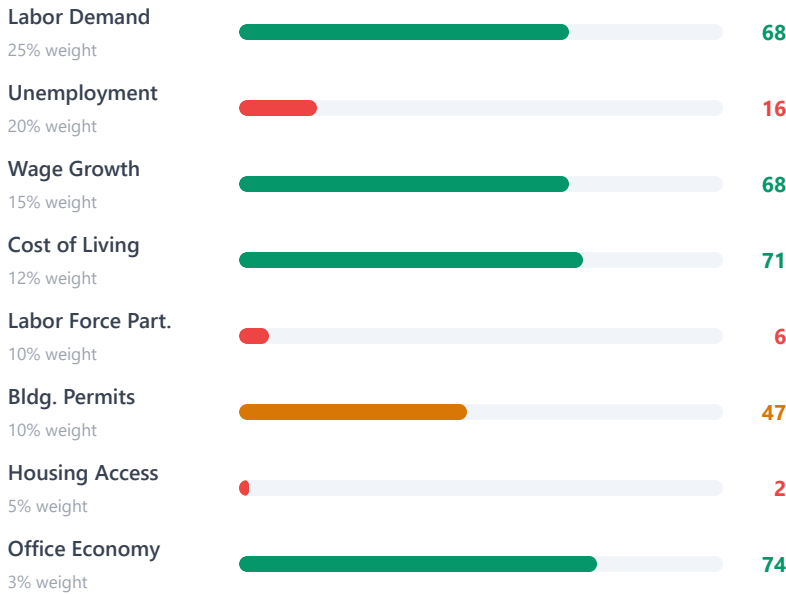
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.6th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-8.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

66 days

median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa's economic character is defined by its severe labor market weaknesses, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and a critically low labor force participation rate of 59.95%, making it a challenging location for businesses and individuals. However, the city's cost of living composite score of 1.83 indicates a below-average cost of living, which could be an attractive feature.

Despite these challenges, Tampa's economy is not without its strengths. The city's nonfarm employment growth of +0.92% YoY and wage growth of +4.86% YoY suggest a healthy expansion, with solid job growth and increasing wages. However, the housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 15.8% YoY to an average of 66 days.

Tampa offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing economy with solid job growth, but the city's labor market weaknesses and slowing housing market pose significant risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering relocation to Tampa is the potential for labor shortages and housing market instability, which could undermine the city's economic advantages.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

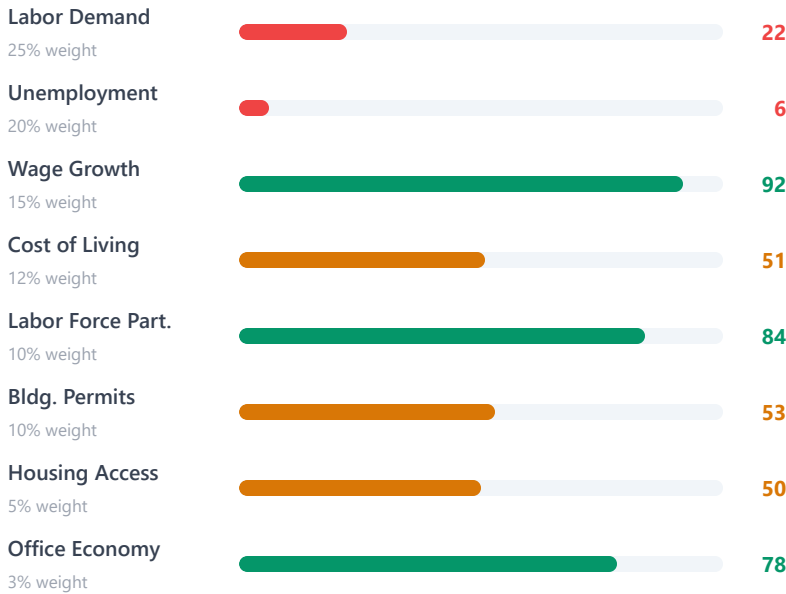
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.2th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

68.2%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

34 days
median, +9.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle's economy earns a below-average grade of B- (45.2nd percentile out of 50 US metros), marked by a mix of strengths and weaknesses. The city's labor market is severely weak, with a high unemployment rate of 5.00% in the bottom tier, but this is countered by a deep labor pool, with a labor force participation rate of 68.24% in the top tier.

Wage growth is robust, with hourly earnings increasing by 7.63% year-over-year, also in the top tier. However, job growth is a concern, with nonfarm employment declining by 0.15% year-over-year, a below-average performance. This tension suggests that wages may be rising due to a shift towards higher-paying jobs, rather than broad labor market health.

Seattle offers a deep labor pool and strong wage growth, but the primary risk is the city's labor market weakness, characterized by high unemployment and slow job growth. The city's housing market is also showing signs of slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.7% year-over-year, although the absolute level of 34 days remains relatively fast. Decision-makers should carefully consider the potential impact of these factors on consumer spending and labor costs when weighing the advantages and disadvantages of locating in Seattle.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

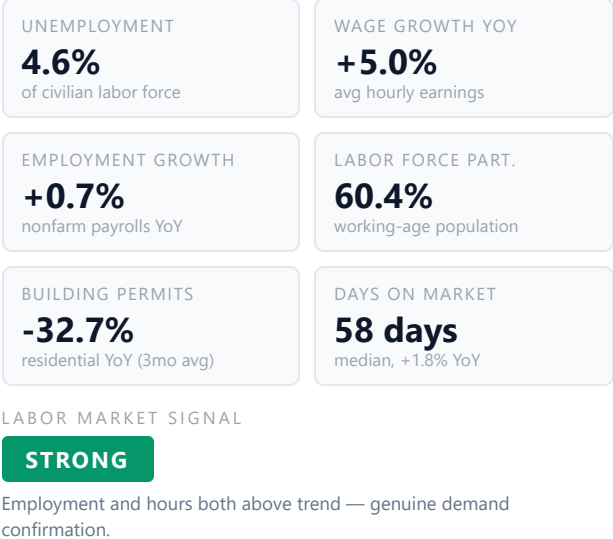
44.8th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville's economy ranks 44.8th percentile overall, with a mix of strengths and weaknesses. The city's labor market is severely weak, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and a labor force participation rate of 60.38%. However, nonfarm employment growth is a bright spot, increasing 0.68% year-over-year, indicating a healthy expansion.

Despite these positives, the city's housing market is a concern. Building permits have declined sharply by 32.70% year-over-year, indicating a contracting housing supply. This, combined with days on market increasing by 1.8% year-over-year to 58 days, suggests a slowing market that may be due to demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization.

In summary, Jacksonville offers a relatively affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 1.44, and solid wage growth, with hourly earnings rising 5.00% year-over-year. However, the city's severe labor market weakness and declining building permits pose a significant threat to its economic health, making it a cautious choice for businesses considering relocation or expansion.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

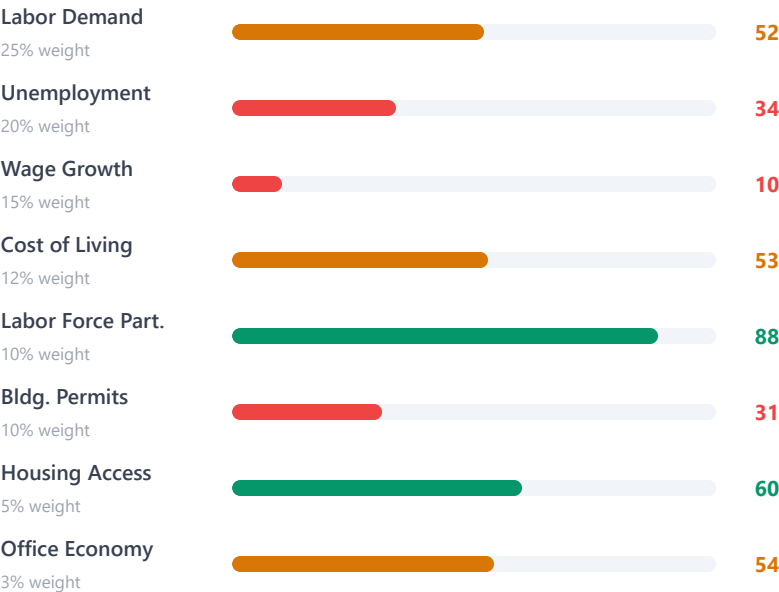
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

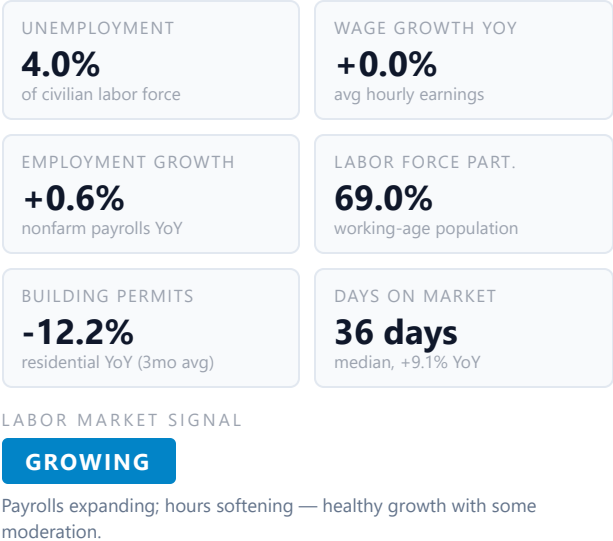
44.1th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington Metro Area Earns a B- Grade, with Labor Force Participation Rate of 69.03% and Stagnant Real Wages.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington area's economic landscape is marked by a labor force participation rate of 69.03%, indicating a deep and engaged labor pool. However, this advantage is tempered by a wage growth rate of +0.03% YoY, suggesting stagnant real wages. The area's unemployment rate of 4.00% also raises concerns about labor market slack, which could facilitate easier hiring but potentially weaken local consumer demand.

The area's housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.1% YoY to an average of 36 days, and a decline in building permits of -12.25% YoY, suggesting that housing supply may not be keeping pace with demand, potentially leading to affordability risks in the future.

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington offers businesses a deep and engaged labor pool, but the primary risk lies in the potential for demand erosion due to stagnant wages and slowing housing market activity. As a result, companies should carefully consider the local consumer demand landscape and potential affordability risks when evaluating this metro area as a business location.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

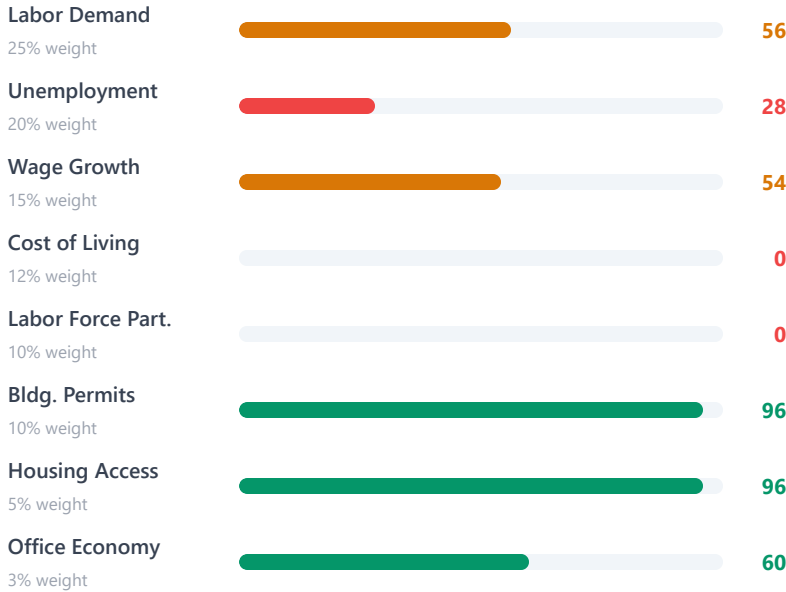
C+

POOR

43.9th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

50.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+144.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

48 days

median, +33.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Providence-Warwick earns a C+ overall grade, reflecting a labor market with significant structural constraints, with a critically low labor force participation rate of 50.77% hindering business expansion or relocation. The city's cost of living composite score of 7.35 places it among the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. An above-average share of office and professional workers could be a mild positive for office-dependent businesses.

The housing market presents conflicting signals, with building permits up 144.37% year-over-year, suggesting an aggressive expansion of housing supply, but days on market have increased by 33.3% to 48 days, indicating a slowing market. Strong employment growth and rising permits suggest normalization, but the high cost of living and low labor force participation rate remain concerns.

Providence offers an above-average professional workforce and an expanding housing supply, but the primary risk is the city's high cost of living and low labor force participation rate, which could limit its appeal to businesses seeking to relocate or expand. Decision-makers must carefully weigh these factors when considering Providence as a potential location.

Cleveland

Cleveland

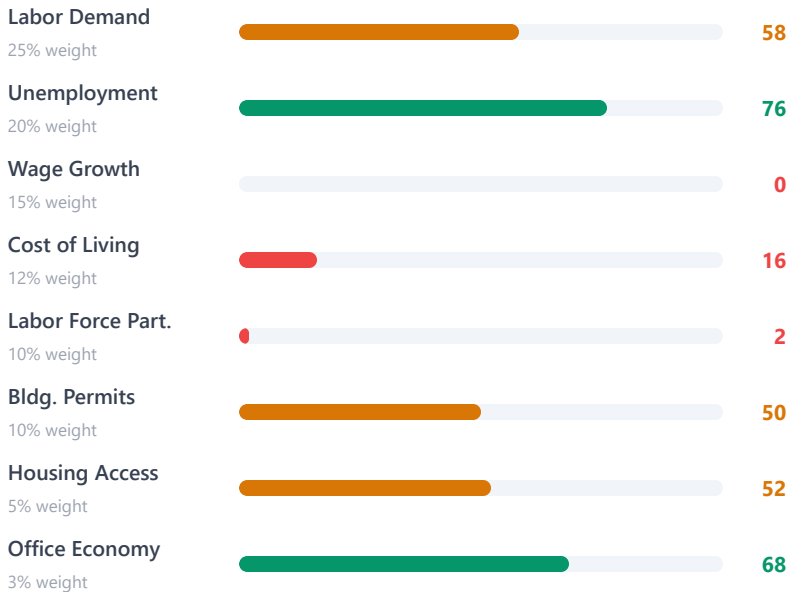
C+

POOR

41.5th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-1.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

58.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

N/A

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

55 days

median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland's economy is defined by low unemployment, critically low labor force participation, and stagnant wage growth, with a single most important takeaway being the city's constrained labor market and high cost of living.

With an unemployment rate of 3.40%, the labor market appears healthy, but this is tempered by a labor force participation rate of 58.01%, indicating a shallow pool of available workers. Wage growth has been declining, with hourly earnings down 1.79% year-over-year, suggesting a softening market. The city's cost of living is also a significant concern, with a composite score of 5.00 placing it among the most expensive metros.

The presence of an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 68th percentile, is a mild positive, but it is overshadowed by the more pressing issues of labor availability and cost of living. Ultimately, Cleveland offers a business a stable, albeit slow-growing, economy with a highly professional workforce, but the primary risk is the constrained labor market and high cost of living, which may hinder the city's economic growth and make it a challenging location for businesses reliant on a deep and skilled labor pool.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

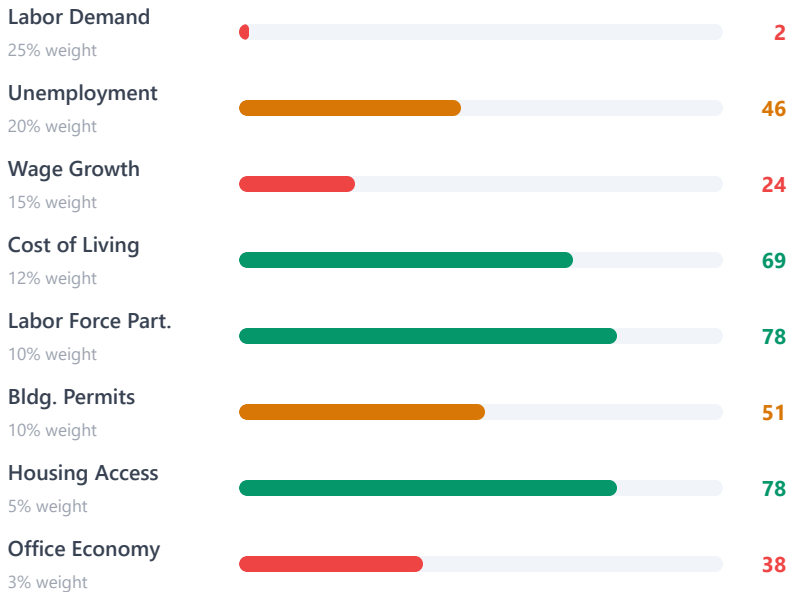
C+

POOR

39.6th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

67.4%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-4.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

30 days

median, +25.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington D.C.'s economic character is defined by its struggling labor market, with a bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -1.63% year-over-year, resulting in job losses and a contraction in the workforce. The city's sluggish wage growth of +1.37% year-over-year suggests a lower cost environment for employers, but also potentially weak worker bargaining power. With a labor force participation rate of 67.37%, the city has a relatively available workforce.

The housing market is also a concern, with days on market increasing by 25.0% year-over-year, and homes now taking an average of 30 days to sell. This slowdown in the housing market, despite being relatively fast compared to other metros, may signal softening demand, particularly given the weak employment growth. The city's below-average office and professional worker share, ranking in the 38th percentile, may pose constraints for businesses seeking specialized or senior talent.

Washington D.C. offers a relatively affordable cost of living, with a score of 2.06, and an available workforce, but the primary risk lies in its struggling labor market and potential demand erosion. The city's economic contraction and softening housing market demand caution, making it essential for businesses to carefully weigh the pros and cons before making a location decision.

Fresno

Fresno

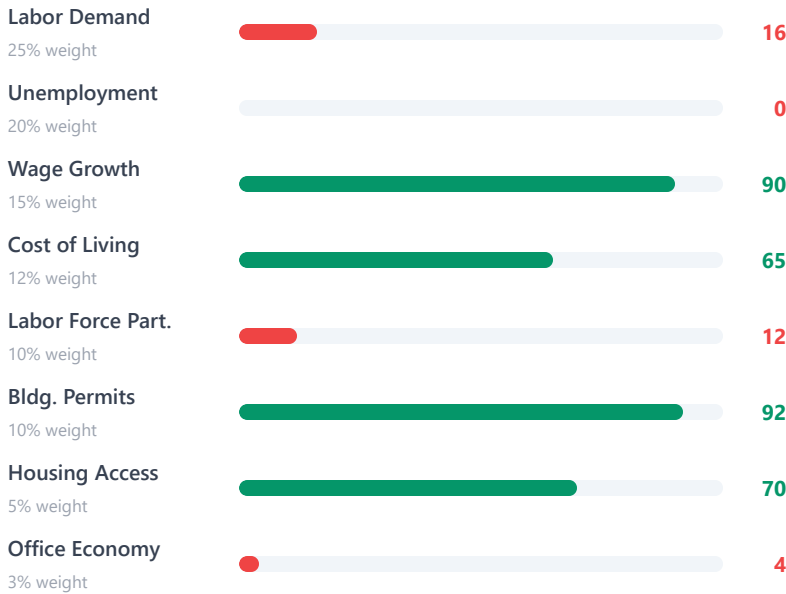
C+

POOR

39.3th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

8.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+62.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

51 days

median, +10.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno's economic landscape is defined by its struggling labor market, with an 8.20% unemployment rate and 60.33% labor force participation, both of which are the lowest in the country. Despite this, hourly earnings are rising by 7.60% YoY, a top-tier metric, suggesting that existing workers are seeing significant wage increases, but the labor market is not creating many new jobs.

The city's low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 4th percentile, is a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the housing supply is expanding aggressively, with building permits up 61.97% YoY, a top-tier metric. Homes are taking 10.9% more days to sell than last year, indicating a slowing market. This rise in days on market may signal demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization, given the weak employment growth.

Fresno offers a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding housing supply, but its labor market weaknesses pose a significant risk. The primary caveat for businesses considering relocation to Fresno is the city's severe labor market challenges, including high unemployment and low labor force participation, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and constrain consumer spending.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

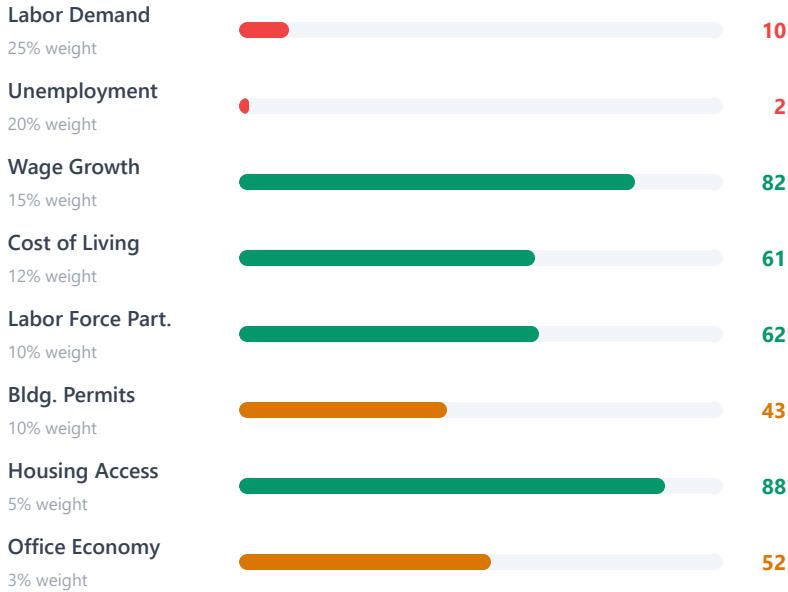
C+

POOR

39.0th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-9.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

52 days

median, +18.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Las Vegas' economic character is defined by its struggling labor market, with a 5.20% unemployment rate and -0.76% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, indicating severe labor market weakness and job losses. Despite this, wage growth remains strong at +6.71% year-over-year, suggesting that those who are employed are seeing significant wage increases. This combination of metrics paints a picture of a city with a challenged economy, where consumer spending may be at risk due to high unemployment.

The strong wage growth, despite weak employment growth, may be due to a mix shift towards higher-paying jobs, rather than broad labor market health. The housing market is also slowing, with days on market increasing by 18.2% year-over-year to an average of 52 days, indicating a relatively slow and buyer-friendly market. This slowdown in the housing market, combined with weak employment growth, suggests that demand may be eroding, rather than the market simply normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Las Vegas offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowing housing market, which may provide opportunities for relocation and expansion. However, the primary risk is the city's weak labor market, with high unemployment and stagnant job growth, which may limit consumer spending and demand for goods and services.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

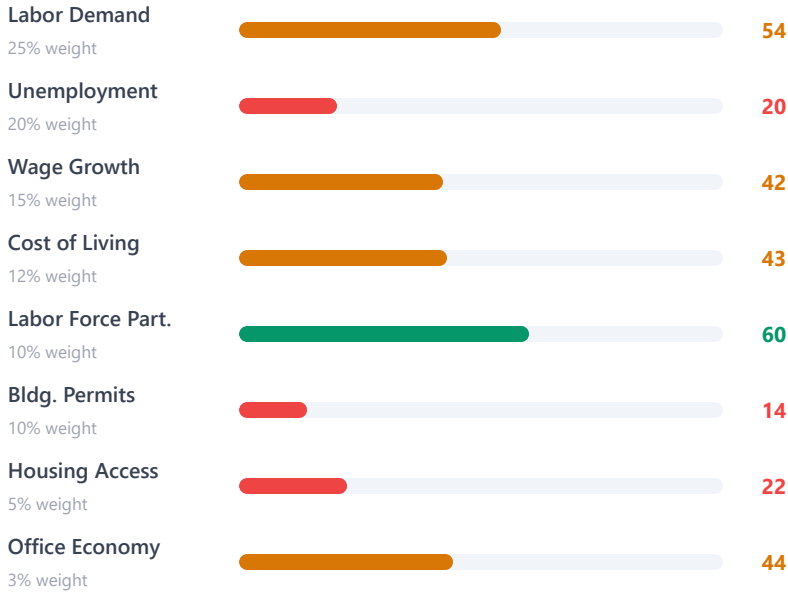
C+

POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-27.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

35 days

median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago's C+ grade and 38.8th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros reflect a labor market with 4.50% unemployment, signaling slack, and a competitive housing market with 35 days on market, indicating a fast pace. The significant 27.41% year-over-year decline in building permits exacerbates affordability concerns and hinders workforce attraction.

The labor force participation rate of 64.75% is a mild positive, but the sharp decline in building permits and rapid home sales suggest a supply-driven scarcity rather than genuine demand strength. This dynamic may create challenges for relocating workers, who face a fast-moving market with limited housing options.

Chicago's labor market offers some slack, potentially easing hiring, but poses significant risks due to its rapidly contracting housing supply and competitive market. The primary caveat for businesses considering location in Chicago is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the city's affordability and housing challenges.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

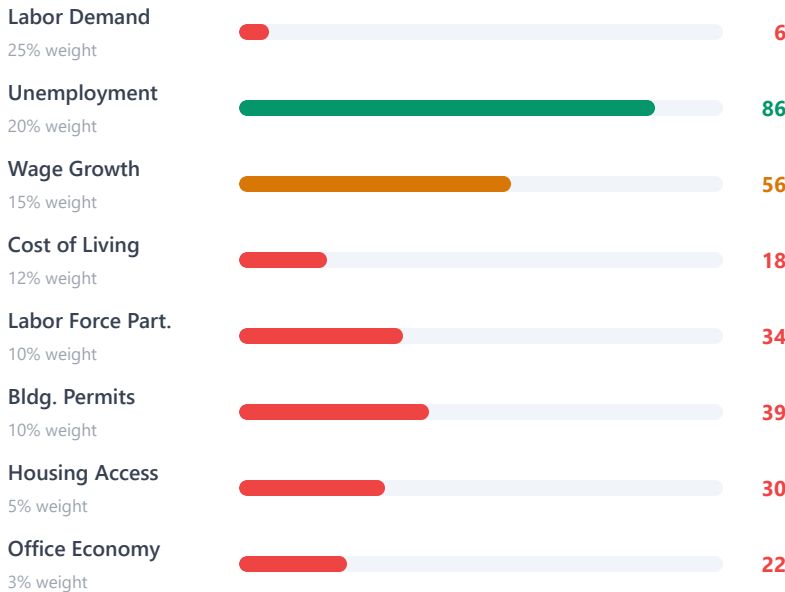
C+

POOR

38.7th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.9%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

63.2%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-10.5%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

33 days
median, +6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Milwaukee's economic character is defined by a tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.10%, and a challenging employment growth story, with a -0.91% year-over-year change in total nonfarm employment. This tension is further complicated by a cost of living composite score of 4.27, indicating that Milwaukee is among the most expensive metros, which can constrain talent acquisition and consumer spending power. The city's overall grade of C+, reflecting a 38.7th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros, suggests a challenging economic environment.

The labor market and workforce profile present a conflicting story. While the low unemployment rate suggests a competitive job market, the labor force participation rate of 63.19% indicates a shallow labor pool. The office and professional worker share is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile, which may pose constraints for specialized or senior roles. The housing market is also slowing, with days on market increasing by 6.5% year-over-year, at 33 days.

In summary, Milwaukee offers a business a highly competitive labor market, but with significant constraints, including a shallow labor pool and high cost of living. The primary risk is that the city's economic growth may be hindered by its inability to attract and retain talent, making it a challenging location for businesses to thrive.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

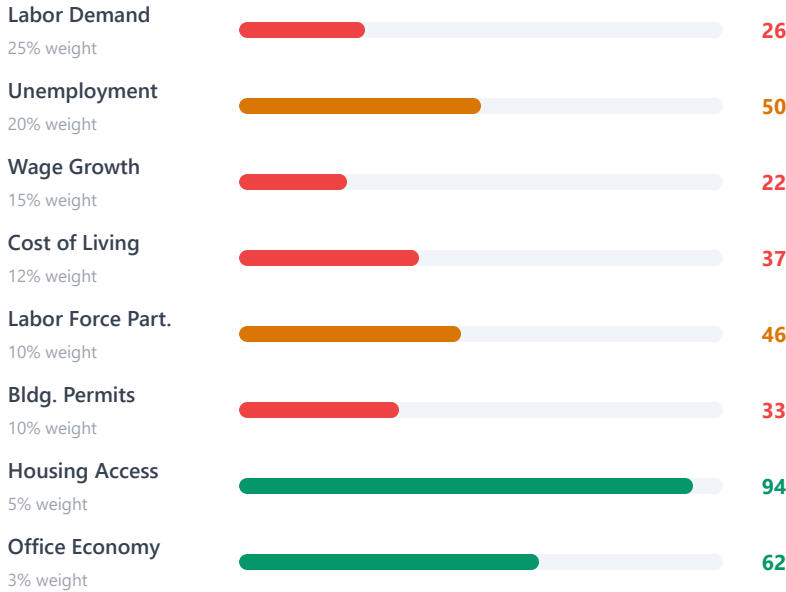
C+

POOR

38.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.2%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-11.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days
median, +27.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore's economy earns a C+ grade, with sluggish growth and affordability concerns being the most significant takeaway. The city's nonfarm employment growth is a notable weakness, with a -0.14% year-over-year change, indicating economic deceleration. Wage growth is also below average, at +1.22% year-over-year, suggesting a lower cost environment for employers but potentially weak worker bargaining power.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 27.6% year-over-year to 37 days, a top-tier score indicating a relatively slow market. This slowdown is concerning, particularly when paired with below-average building permits growth, at -11.14% year-over-year, suggesting that demand erosion may be a more significant factor than healthy normalization. The presence of an above-average office and professional worker share, ranked in the 62nd percentile, is a mild positive, but it is overshadowed by the broader economic concerns.

Baltimore offers businesses a lower-cost labor environment, but the primary risk is the city's slowing economic growth and potential demand erosion in the housing market. Decision-makers should carefully weigh the benefits of a relatively affordable labor market against the potential long-term risks of a stagnating economy and tightening housing supply.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

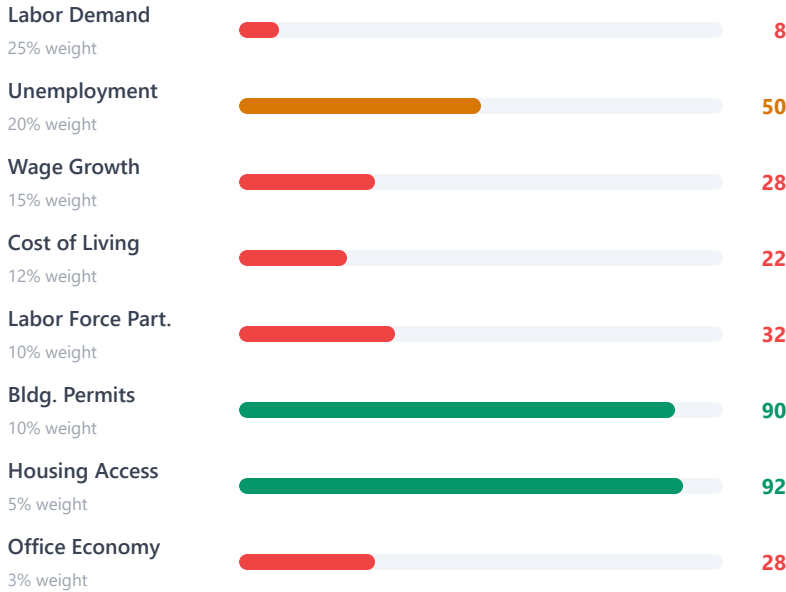


VERY POOR

36.5th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

63.1%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+57.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +21.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati's struggling labor market is the single most important takeaway, with a bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -0.52% year-over-year, indicating job losses and stagnation. The city's labor force participation rate of 63.08% is also below average, suggesting a shallow labor pool. This challenging environment is further exacerbated by sluggish wage growth of +1.53% year-over-year, making it difficult for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Despite the labor market woes, Cincinnati is experiencing an aggressive expansion in housing supply, with building permits increasing by 57.47% year-over-year. However, this growth is not translating to a strong housing market, as homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market rising by 21.6% year-over-year to an average of 45 days.

Cincinnati's business environment is marked by a low cost of living, but its struggling labor market and slowing housing market pose significant risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering location in Cincinnati is the potential for demand erosion and talent attraction challenges, which could outweigh the benefits of a relatively affordable cost of living.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

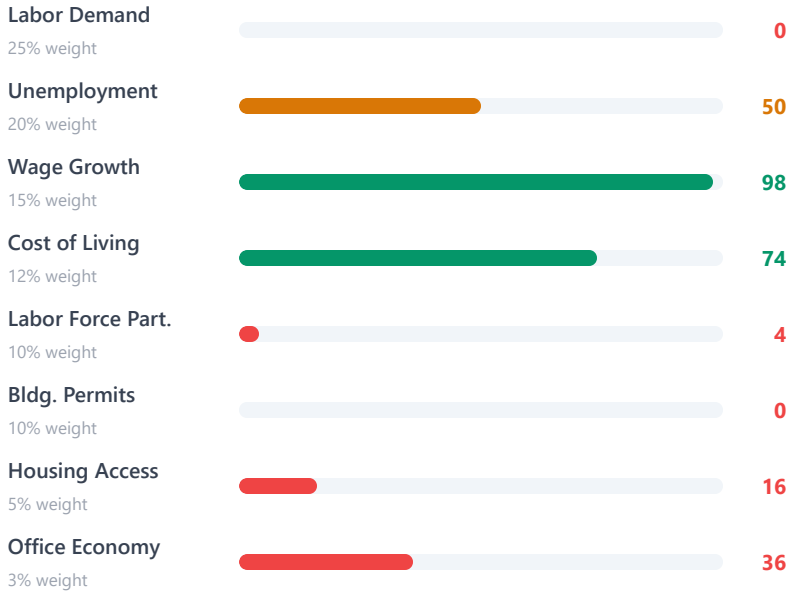


VERY POOR

35.8th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+10.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

59.0%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-46.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days
median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area earns a C grade, ranking 35.8th out of 50 US metros, with a challenging economic landscape marked by critically low labor market participation and declining nonfarm employment growth. Only 58.99% of working-age adults are employed or actively looking for work, and nonfarm employment has seen a staggering -1.34% year-over-year decline.

The housing market is also experiencing significant stress, with building permits plummeting by 46.79% year-over-year and homes selling in just 36 days on average, with a -5.3% year-over-year change indicating a speeding up of the market. This scarcity-driven demand is likely to exacerbate affordability concerns, despite the area's relatively affordable cost of living composite score of 1.53.

The primary risk for businesses in this metro area is the constrained labor market and accelerating housing costs, which may hinder talent attraction and retention. With rapidly rising wages and a scarce housing supply, the area's affordable cost of living advantage may ultimately erode, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully weigh these factors when considering a location decision.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

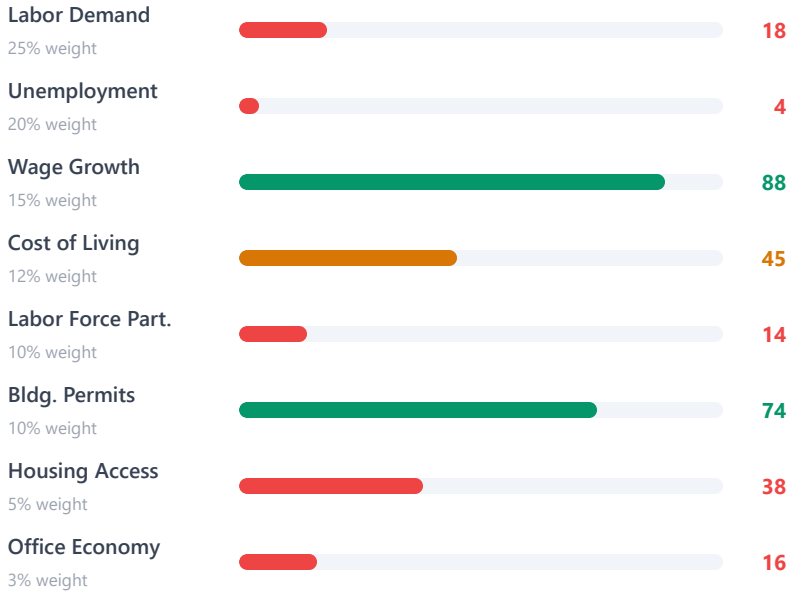


VERY POOR

35.0th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.4%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+18.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

54 days
median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area earns a C grade, ranking 35th among 50 US metros, with a struggling labor market and stagnant job creation. Unemployment rates at 5.10% and labor force participation at 60.37% are both bottom-tier metrics, indicating severe weakness.

Despite these challenges, wage growth has been remarkably strong, with hourly earnings rising by 7.54% year-over-year, a top-tier metric. This suggests that certain sectors or industries may be experiencing growth and driving up wages. The office and professional worker share ranks 16th percentile, limiting the appeal for knowledge-economy businesses.

The bottom line is that Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario offers a low-cost labor market with rising wages, but the primary risk is the weak labor market and limited workforce availability. Businesses considering relocation must weigh the potential benefits of lower labor costs against the challenges of attracting and retaining skilled workers.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro



VERY POOR

33.4th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.8%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

66.2%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

49 days
median, -3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area earns a C grade, ranking 33.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, driven by severe labor market weakness. Unemployment rates are high at 4.90%, posing a significant risk to consumer spending. Job losses are evident, with nonfarm employment growth contracting by -0.69% year-over-year, indicating a stagnant job market.

Wage growth remains solid, with hourly earnings increasing by 4.78% year-over-year, providing some support to consumer spending. However, the low office and professional worker share, ranking 12th percentile, constrains knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is characterized by a supply squeeze, with building permits declining by -18.14% year-over-year, and homes selling faster, with days on market decreasing by -3.9% year-over-year to an average of 49 days.

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro offers a cost advantage, with above-average affordability, but this comes with significant labor market risks and a tightening housing supply. Businesses considering this location must be aware of the potential for labor market instability and limited access to professional talent, which could hinder growth and competitiveness.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

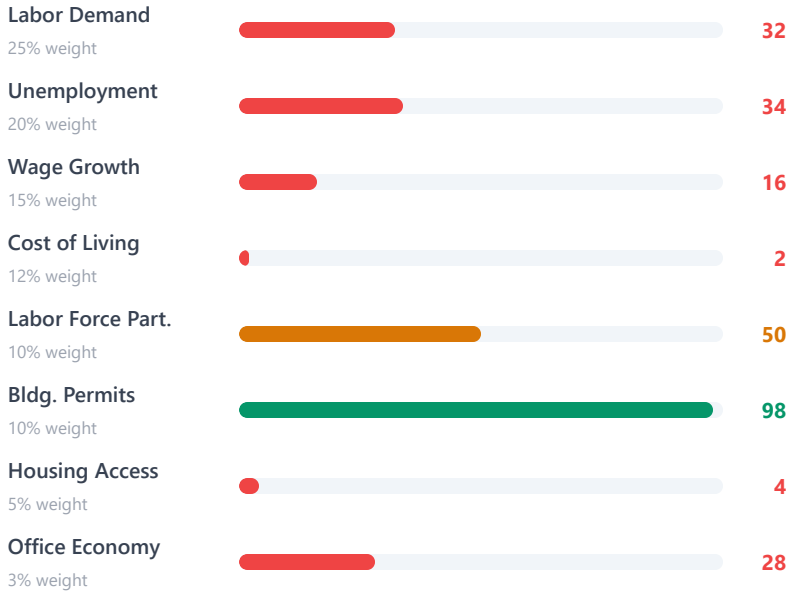


VERY POOR

33.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+195.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

24 days

median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Jose's economy earns a C grade, ranking 33rd percentile, due to sluggish growth and high costs. The city's 4.00% unemployment rate and -0.16% nonfarm employment growth suggest a labor market with slack, while stagnant wage growth of +0.59% YoY indicates limited worker leverage.

The housing market is aggressive, with building permits increasing 195.09% YoY, but the days on market have risen 9.1% YoY, with homes selling in just 24 days. This suggests a highly competitive market, with new hires facing significant housing challenges. Weak employment growth and rising days on market may indicate demand erosion, a risk for businesses.

San Jose offers a highly competitive and expensive market, with a rapidly expanding housing supply, but significant challenges in talent acquisition and consumer spending power. The primary risk for businesses is demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a highly competitive housing market, impacting the city's long-term economic viability.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

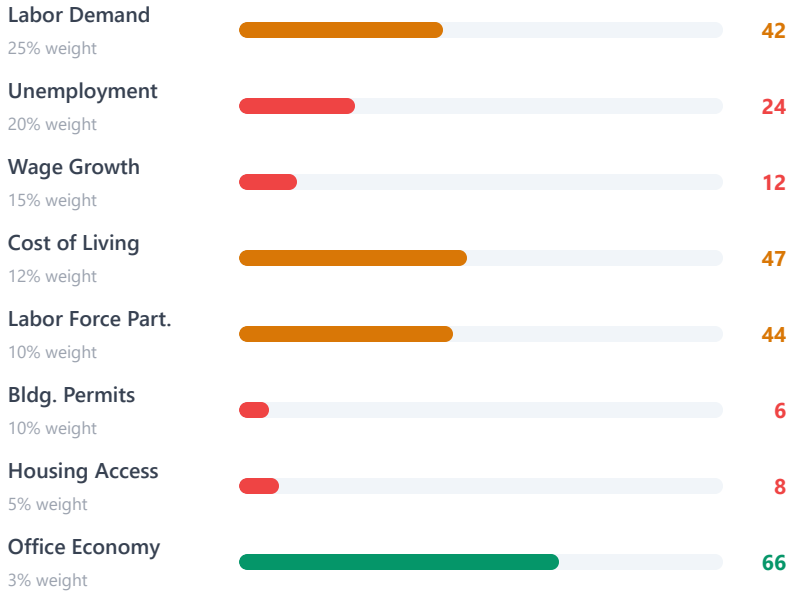
C-

CRITICAL

30.1th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-35.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

67 days

median, +11.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando's economic character is defined by its struggling labor market and housing supply constraints, earning it a C- overall grade. The city's 4.40% unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth of +0.37% YoY indicate limited leverage for workers. A sharp decline in building permits of -35.64% YoY exacerbates affordability issues and hinders workforce attraction.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 11.7% YoY to 67 days. This slowdown may be a sign of demand erosion, given weak employment growth of +0.24% YoY and declining building permits. Orlando's above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 66th percentile, is a mild positive, but it may not offset broader economic challenges.

Orlando offers businesses a labor market with some slack, potentially easing hiring. However, the primary risk is the city's struggling housing supply and stagnant wage growth. The sharp decline in building permits and slowing housing market indicate a deteriorating economic environment, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad



CRITICAL

29.4th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.0%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days
median, +5.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego's sluggish labor market and high cost of living define its economic character, with a 4.40% unemployment rate and 62.01% labor force participation, indicating a shallow and stagnant labor pool. The city's nonfarm employment growth is a mere 0.35% year-over-year, reflecting economic deceleration.

The housing market is marked by a 5.6% year-over-year increase in days on market to an average of 38 days, indicating a slowing pace that may signal softening demand. San Diego's low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 18th percentile, is a concern for knowledge-economy businesses.

San Diego offers a challenging location for businesses, with a high cost of living and a shallow labor pool, making it difficult to attract and retain talent. The city's economic deceleration, reflected in its 0.35% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, may lead to weakened local consumer demand and limited job opportunities, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors before making a location decision.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

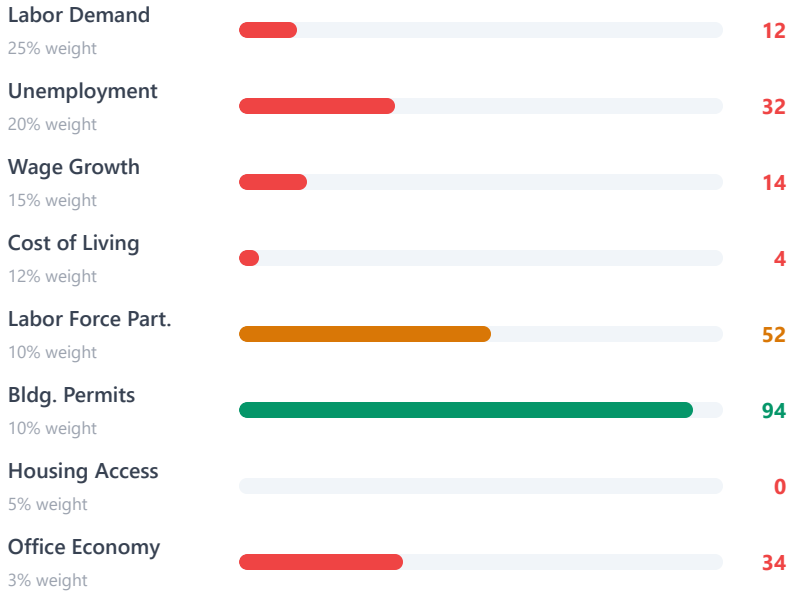
C-

CRITICAL

27.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+86.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

29 days

median, -6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Francisco's economic character is defined by its struggling labor market and extremely high cost of living, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of -0.52% year-over-year, indicating significant job losses. The city's overall grade of C-, ranking 27.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, reflects its stagnant wage growth at +0.49% year-over-year, indicating little leverage for workers and a softening market.

The housing market tells a conflicting story, with building permits increasing by 86.01% year-over-year, indicating an aggressive expansion of housing supply. Homes are selling extremely fast, with an average of 29 days on market, and this velocity is accelerating, with a -6.5% year-over-year change. The cost of living composite score of 5.79, ranking in the bottom tier, highlights the city's extreme expense.

San Francisco offers a highly competitive and fast-moving housing market, but its struggling labor market and extremely high cost of living pose significant risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering location in San Francisco is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the city's high cost of living and competitive housing market.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

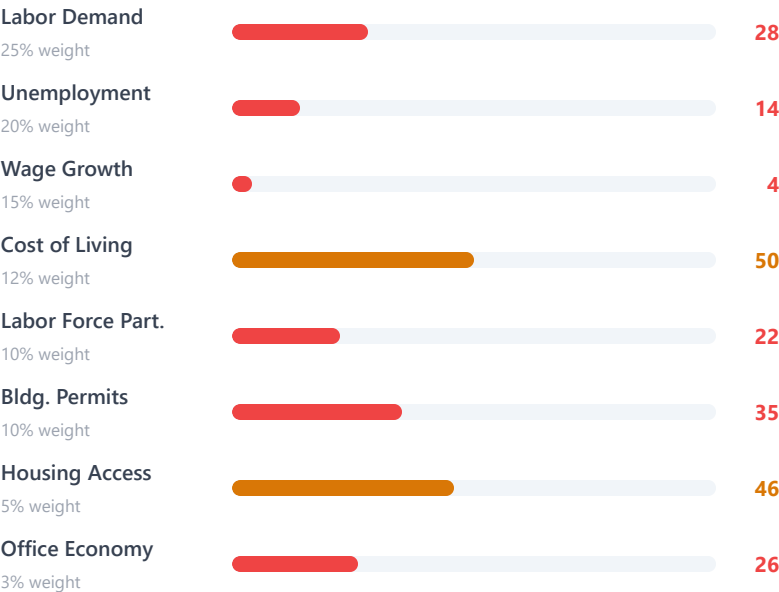
D

EMERGENCY

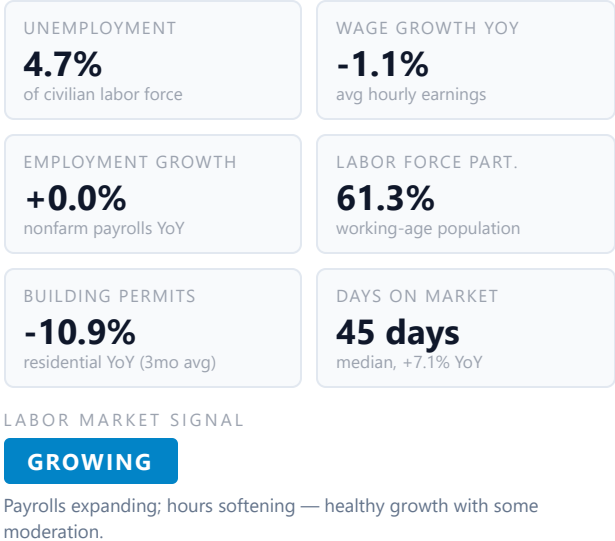
25.1th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit's economic landscape is marked by severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of -1.13% year-over-year, resulting in a shallow labor pool and limited job opportunities. Below-average labor force participation of 61.27% and sluggish nonfarm employment growth of just 0.01% year-over-year further exacerbate the city's economic struggles.

The city's housing market is also experiencing challenges, with building permits declining by 10.94% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 7.1% year-over-year, resulting in homes taking an average of 45 days to sell. This slowdown in housing velocity suggests a scenario of demand erosion, rather than a healthy normalization of the market, likely driven by the lack of wage growth and limited job opportunities.

Detroit offers a business environment with significant challenges, including a weak labor market and softening housing demand. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Detroit is the potential for prolonged economic stagnation, driven by structural labor market weaknesses and declining housing market momentum.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

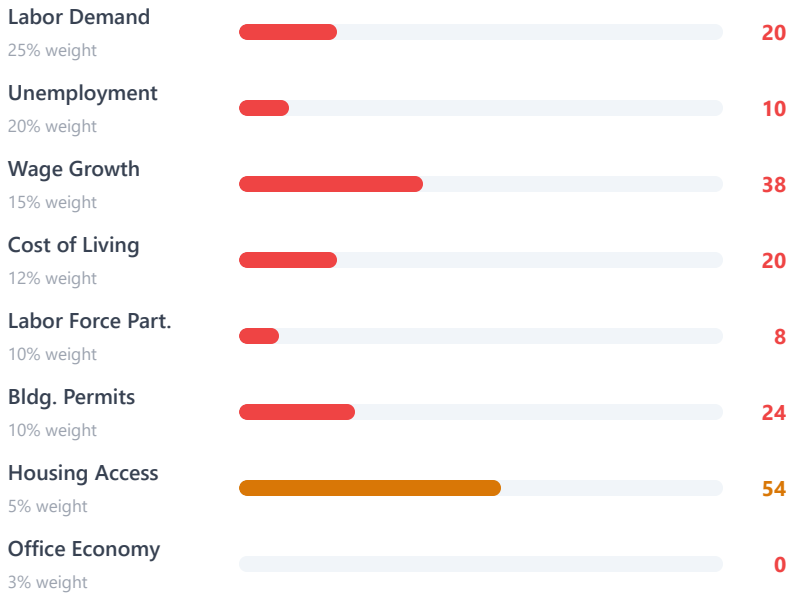
D

EMERGENCY

21.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.1%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-15.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area earns a D grade, with a struggling economy driven by a severely weak labor market. The unemployment rate is 4.80%, and the labor force participation rate is a critically low 60.12%. This is compounded by below-average nonfarm employment growth of -0.27% year-over-year, indicating economic deceleration.

The data reveals tensions in the housing market, with a cost of living composite score of 4.08, suggesting a relatively affordable environment. However, the decline in building permits by -15.51% year-over-year raises concerns about future affordability. The increase in days on market by 8.3% year-over-year, resulting in an average of 39 days, may indicate softening demand rather than a healthy normalization of the market.

The Sacramento market offers a relatively affordable cost of living, but its severely weak labor market and declining economic growth pose significant risks for businesses. The primary caveat for businesses considering relocation or expansion in this market is the structural constraint of a critically low labor force participation rate, which may limit workforce availability and hinder growth prospects.